Battlefields

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/57689074.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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catradora, Post-Canon, Romance, Established Relationship, relationship drama, hurting the ones you love, Misunderstandings, Character Study, Canon Lesbian Relationship, True Love, Idiots in Love, Lasting Love, couple fights, Crying, Relationship Advice, couples therapy, Personal Growth, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Glimbow, seamista - Freeform, Entrapdak, spinnetossa, Seduction, Disaster Lesbians, Adora and Catra are Bad at Feelings

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by backintimePBA

Summary

Six months have passed since end of the war, and Adora and Catra struggle to navigate their new lives as a couple. Fractures appear in their relationship as Adora's new responsibilities as She-Ra drive a wedge between them. After a harsh argument while visiting Bright Moon Castle they become determined to mend their problems, leading them to discover new perspectives on love and commitment from their friends.

A cosy story of five couples, each with their own struggles and philosophies on love, framed around Catra and Adora's efforts to overcome their own emotional turmoil. Includes some soft angst/drama. Cautiously rated soft M for sexual insinuations.

Dreams

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra have a late night conversation that doesn't go to plan. Glimmer attempts to tempt Bow. Mermista avoids Sea Hawk. Hordak tells Entrapta that he's restless. Netossa and Spinnerella make a secret party plan.

The sticky, cloying summer heat stirred Catra from a dreamless sleep. She kicked off the bed covers and stared exhausted at the ceiling and tried, unsuccessfully, to will herself back to sleep. She didn't expect it to work, and it didn't, and neither did the six different positions she tried lying in before she gave up and sat up.

Though the tiny room was in near pitch darkness, by the starlight streaming through the open window she could make out every detail of the room and of her and Adora's meagre possessions: a handful of books on a high shelf, a single chair by the window, a zither that Adora had bought on a whim and played exactly once four months ago, a chest of clothes, and a small bottle of perfume that Adora had bought her for her first birthday since they became a couple. Compared to the homes of many of their friends their living space was more than a little spartan—perhaps living under the Horde for so many years had given them both an appreciation for simple living—but she treasured every bit of it.

What there wasn't, for the fifth night in a row, was Adora.

Catra lay sprawled out on the sweat-soaked sheets for a few minutes, then with a groan she got up, climbed out the window, and hopped up onto the roof. Adora was sat there with her back to her, gazing into the unlit night.

It had been a whirlwind six months since peace had come to Etheria. *Real,* joyful, jubilant… *choking* peace. To Catra peace seemed harder than war. War… Well, she knew her way around

war. They both did. Peace was just… work. Just a whole lot of hard, hard work.

For a while they had stayed in Adora's old room in Bright Moon Castle, but that didn't last long. Yes, the waterfall made Catra need to pee *all the time,* but the real problem was privacy. She and Adora were simply never alone. Never *alone* alone. After so much time apart they needed a fresh start, and so they moved out here to the very edge of the Kingdom. The little stone cottage sat on the edge of a lake in the forest: a single storey and two rooms, barely big enough for even one person. It still smelled of ancient soil and young pine. To Catra it was almost perfect.

Catra sat down and rested her head on Adora's shoulder.

"Hey, Adora," she said though a barely-stifled yawn.

Adora wordlessly put her arm around her and gently kissed her head.

Though the cottage was small it was elevated slightly above the broad flatlands, and so from the rooftop the view was striking. In the far distance a tiny glint of light that was Bright Moon Castle was just visible. Beyond it the Blue Mountains shone in the starlight, but Catra knew that to Adora's eyes there was barely anything to see beyond the treetops.

"I never expected there to be so much to rebuild," said Adora at last. "I'm sorry. I was going to show you the universe, and every day there's more to do. More towns to rebuild, more families to reunite, more treaties to strengthen…"

Catra laughed softly. "You know you don't need to show me the *universe.* Don't be stupid."

"Don't I?" said Adora, sombrely. "I just… I just thought when the war was over…"

Catra raised her head and tried to catch Adora's gaze. Adora remained staring blindly across the forest.

"You don't have to keep doing it," said Catra. "It's not like you're the only girl in town with connections. What's even the point of the Princess Alliance if none of those layabout Princesses are going to step up and—"

"Without She-Ra there won't *be* a Princess Alliance by the end of the year!" Adora interrupted. She stood up abruptly. "The Kingdoms are already drifting apart now without the threat of the Horde to unite them. It'll be like the old days, with all our old divisions and rivalries. We have the whole universe on our doorstep now—who knows what's out there if we're not united? Etheria still needs me… Needs She-Ra…"

Catra scowled at her. "Oh, so what, magical perfect She-Ra just needs to keep saving the world forever now? You just have to play diplomat for the rest of your life?"

"Catra, this is important! I'm Glimmer's foreign minister now. I have an obligation—"

"An *obligation?"* Catra hissed. "Don't you have an obligation to yourself? To us? It's been six months and I feel like I *barely* ever see you."

"What are you talking about? We just spent two weeks together on that diplomatic mission to Mystacor."

"No, *She-Ra* and I just spent two weeks together!" Catra was aware she was raising her voice, but pressed on. "Two weeks where I was bored out of my skull while you were…" she struggled for words "…attending ceremonial tea parties and… ritual… spa days!"

"Um, the spa day was for both of us!" said Adora, throwing her arms up in exasperation. "*You* just don't know how to relax!"

"Since when do you relax?"

"Since I left the Fright Zone!"

There was an awful silence. Not for the first time both of them felt grateful for the miles of empty country around them. In the past Catra might've vanished into that empty country, perhaps for days at a time, but she now knew that never solved anything.

She just wish she knew what did.

She closed her eyes, and patiently counted to ten.

"Catra, I—" began Adora.

Catra held up her hand until she finished counting.

"Look, don't worry about it," she said at last. "I-I'm sorry, alright?" She smiled sheepishly. "You know I'm proud of you… my little diplomat. You do so much… It's one of the things that make you so special."

Adora looked away, blushing. "No, I'm— Well, I just want you to be happy. I promise you don't have to do any spa days if you don't want to."

"Aha, sure. Sure," said Catra, letting out a nervous laugh.

She sat and stared out across the forest. She swished her tail across the roof tiles a couple of times before yawning widely.

"It's really late," said Adora, yawning too. "Maybe we should some sleep. We have a big day ahea—*Ahhh!"*

Adora shrieked as she slipped off the roof. A tree branch broke her fall and she landed, splayed out, on the grass below. Catra peaked over the edge of the roof, and her concerned expression quickly gave way to a genuine deep cackle.

"Nice job, idiot," she said affectionately. "Come to bed. And no more roof parties."

With two nimble leaps Catra jumped down and back in through the bedroom window. A moment passed before Adora was sure

she could feel her legs, and wearily made her way in through the door.

It was finally quiet in what used to be the Bright Moon war room. Glimmer slumped into her chair as attendants cleared away the last few bundles of paperwork and other minutia. She waved a hand wearily to dim the lights. It was late, and after burning the midnight oil it was nice to finally be alone for a moment.

Well, almost alone.

Bow placed his hands on her shoulders and massaged her aching muscles firmly but gently. She almost sank into her seat.

"You're so tense," he said. "You need to slow down. You don't have to manage everything."

"Yes, I do. You know how important this is, Bow," she replied between winces of discomfort. "The peace and prosperity of all Etheria depends on it. Every detail has to be absolutely perfect, and the Princesses will start arriving as early as tomorrow."

"Glimmer, this isn't exactly your first party. Everything will be fine."

"It's not a party, Bow; it's a conference," said Glimmer, a little haughtily. "Just because Catra dismissed the whole plan as a 'Princess Party' doesn't make it true. Okay, there *is* a party, naturally. Most of the Princesses are suckers for a formal event… But it's more than that! This will be the first time all the Princesses of Etheria will be under one roof in years, with days of talks either side. It'll be a chance to finally lay out the terms of the new peace."

Bow planted a kiss on the top of her head. "Well, we do just have a tendency to resolve everything with parties… and sleepovers,

and sometimes brunches, which is kinda weird, now that I think about it. But it's going to be fine. You're doing an incredible job, because you're an incredible Queen."

She glanced upwards to ensure the last of the servants had left the room, and reached up to touch his hand. She stood and faced him. In the dim light it felt as though the world beyond them and all the talk of trade and border deals had suddenly faded into nothingness. Glimmer looked up into Bow's eyes. She sparkled in the low crystal light.

"Wow," said Bow, instinctively pulling her closer. "You know it's been so busy lately, I can't remember the last time it was just you and me, like this."

They kissed tenderly. Glimmer looked up at Bow and gave him a devilish look.

"Tell me you love me," she said.

Bow almost laughed in response. "Of course I love you," he said.

She grinned widely. "Why don't we make tonight the night?"

Bow relaxed his grip on her and blinked sheepishly. "Well, I…"

She gripped him more tightly in response. "I want to do something really special for you," she said, and suddenly ~teleported~—

—them both to Glimmer's bedroom. Bow took a moment to rebalance himself on the floating platform as Glimmer ~teleported~ again onto her bed. She snapped her fingers and sent a series of sparks to a dozen or so candles around the room. To Bow's amazement he found he was still holding her dress—a new trick he had no idea she'd mastered.

"Why don't you come here and make yourself… more comfortable," she said, trying her best to recline seductively on the too-soft bed.

Bow sat at the edge of the bed and looked around the room anxiously. "It looks like the party isn't the only thing you've been planning in a lot of detail."

Glimmer suddenly looked panicked. "Oh no. Is it too much? I just wanted it to be perfect."

"No, no, it's incredible! *You're* incredible. This is all just… so…"

"Bow, look at me," Glimmer said flatly.

Their gazes met and the air between them was electric. They both felt their minds were working at a thousand miles per hour. And then, in a blink of an eye, the tension was over.

"Maybe I should—" began Bow.

"Yeah, of course, it's late, and—" said Glimmer.

The two of them talked over each other in fragments for a few seconds. They laughed nervously and loudly, and said their goodnights. Bow stumbled down the steps, unable to take his eyes off Glimmer until she was out of view. A moment later the door closed gently behind him as he made his way to his own room down the hall.

Glimmer fell back onto her bedsheets and stared at the ceiling. She swore loudly.

Daybreak in Salineas was anything but peaceful. With the population of the Kingdom returning in its masses the docks were thriving, bringing an unprecedented amount of desperately-needed wealth into the ascendant Kingdom, but to Mermista all the real action happened under the waves. The crabs were building new nesting burrows in the shallows; schools of young

angelfish were making their way through the warm waters; in the depths two solitary sharks were patiently testing each other's territory. She could hear it all, but the ships and the sailors made it all the harder.

"Mermista, my sweet!" shouted Sea Hawk from the palace grounds outside. "I have returned, as promised, from distant shores to once again be by your side!"

And then there was that.

Mermista opened her eyes and clambered to the window.

"Do you mind!?" she yelled. "I'm trying to meditate!"

Sea Hawk posed heroically on the seashell cobbles, looking up at her sixth floor window. "What!?" he shouted.

Mermista groaned. "I said—!" she began, before realising the inanity he was dragging her into. She signalled to an attendant to bring him to her chambers and sat patiently at her dressing table. Several minutes later he appeared at her door and the two were alone.

"My Princess, in your *honour* I have completed your grand quest. In every port of the Silver Sea, from the frozen north to the tropical south, invitations have been sent out. I now return for the grandest adventure of all! The adventure… of love!"

Mermista looked at him blankly. "Ugh," she began, "it's too early for this, Sea Hawk. You know my routine: yoga, meditation, body, face, coffee… then you. You'd think with a whole Kingdom under my rule I could get a mocha that would last until the next morning, but *apparently* it doesn't work like that. Can't you just come back in an hour?"

Sea Hawk smoothed his moustache. "If I didn't know any better I'd say something was bothering you, my love."

Mermista shot him a venomous look. The words "yes, you" felt loaded in her mouth, but she knew she wouldn't mean it. Her expression mellowed. "It's… nothing." She sighed. "It's this stupid Bright Moon party. Did you know this is exactly how the first Princess Alliance was founded? That'll be Bow's stupid idea; he's using historical precedence to give this whole thing legitimacy. It's just got me thinking… you know, about the past and stuff… It's fine."

She turned back to her dressing table and focused intensely under her eyes. A moment later Sea Hawk, with uncanny grace, slipped past her to lean against the table to face her again.

"We're doing that thing again," he said. "That thing we talked about."

"What, you're lecturing me on Sparkle's advice now?" she said bitterly. "You're some kind of font of wisdom all of a sudden? That was never part of the agreement. It doesn't *work* this way."

"Mermista, I understand if you still can't let me in—"

"Let you *in?"* Mermista growled. "What are you even talking about? Alright, I might be a little moody for the next few days. Big deal. Not everything has to be a whole conversation!"

"Oh-o, you forget how well I know you, my jewel of the sea," chuckled Sea Hawk. "You can't just keep building walls to keep me out forever. We both promised to work on all our faults together, remember? I've stopped ruining all our dates. I haven't even started a single fire for months."

"And the whole world appreciates it, babe," said Mermista, getting up and dragging several items from her closet. "Look, it really is nothing. I'll be *fine.* I'm better than I ever have been before. *We're* better than we ever have been before. Now listen, we've got like six hours before we all set off for Bright Moon. Make sure you have your bags packed…"

"My darling—" began Sea Hawk.

“Anyway,” she continued, “I’ve probably taken up enough of your time this morning or whatever. I should probably get going.”

Sea Hawk looked at her in confusion. “But this is your boudoir!”

“Sure, whatever,” said Mermista, avoiding his gaze. “I need to hit the gym. I’ll be back in—ugh, what did I say? Six hours? Yeah, I’ll see you then.”

“Mermista!” Sea Hawk called out, but it was too late. The door closed behind her.

“I didn’t even know the palace had a gym,” he said to himself.

Hordak glowered in the shadows. For all his power and intelligence, it still came down to a matter of discipline and will. For to err here was to forfeit the entire effort, yet he knew he had to press onwards. There was no other way.

With great determination he blended one part bright rose and two parts vermillion with just a touch of white and applied it to the canvas. He smiled with dark satisfaction. It was a perfect match for the flowers arranged on the table in front of him.

“How about now?” said Entrapta, watching him from the window seat. “Can we run the experiment *now?”*

Hordak licked the tip of his brush and dappled on the bright stamens. “I still do not see the need for urgency. The day is young. What was the value of teaching me patience if you wish me to abandon it so readily?”

Entrapta looked at him sourly. “There was a time when you couldn’t wait to let me sieve your brain through a neural differential analysis. It was your favourite thing in the world.”

"And it still is, but you recall how it used to be. How the rage and revulsion lead me. Was there not a reason you lead me to pursue other interests? It was you who first put a brush in my hand. Did you not have every intention to make me… better?"

Entrapta shrugged sheepishly. "Well, sure. I guess I just never expected it to work so well."

"Then you are a finer scientist than you expected to be," said Hordak, looking at her with a smile. Entrapta blushed.

She ambulated with her hair behind him and looked at his latest work. Like all his paintings it was not so much realistic as an expressionist nightmare of dour colours and crimson smears, which even to Entrapta seemed like an unusual portrayal for a still life of flowers, dishes and tiny foods, but he was definitely improving by leaps and bounds. She sometimes wondered if this was simply how he saw the world. Personally she preferred pictures of small animals, but she hadn't the nerve to suggest the subject to him just yet.

He cleaned his brush carefully and laid it down. "But perhaps," he said, "I have kept you waiting too long. You may conduct your experiment."

Entrapta's face lit up. "Really? Ahh, it's going to be so much fun! Come on, I've worked on a quicker way to my lab." She gripped his hand and led him away.

Hordak followed, although he found her pace hard to keep up with. "The other one brought you more messages this morning," he added helpfully.

"You mean Wrong Hordak," Entrapta said, opening up a new secret passage.

Hordak groaned. He hated that appellation for his counterpart. "Quite. Another invitation has arrived from Queen Glimmer for her… *party."* He spoke the word like it was poison in his mouth.

"That's fine," said Entrapta, entering the access code to her lab and dragging him inside. "I still don't want to go. I'm far too busy for that kind of thing. She won't mind."

"I don't think—" Hordak paused as she carried him into an elaborate chair and began strapping him in. "I don't think that's wise. Your Kingdom has not fared well by the war. I would think it essential to establish a new role for yourself in the new order."

"Oh, my Kingdom. Right," said Entrapta, as if she'd forgotten it existed. She began plugging a complex mechanism into the base of his skull. "I don't know, Dryl's doing just fine these days. The factory that makes those tiny blue diodes is back in operation, so it'll probably be alright until I need some of those tiny green diodes."

Hordak looked up at her as best he could, given the restraints. "I don't believe your blasé attitude to be genuine. I think it best we attend."

Entrapta looked nervous as she pulled up a large control panel. "I don't know. I still don't think the others really understand. You remember what happened when we tried going to Scorpia's birthday party. I think she liked it, but everyone else…"

"I'm no longer the man I was then!" Hordak protested. "I have grown. I have changed. I have many witticisms and anecdotes now. I have almost mastered telling a joke. Every day I become less the genetically-designed conqueror of worlds that I was created to be. But I cannot keep growing within the walls of this castle indefinitely."

"I don't know… It's wonderful that you feel so confident, Hordak, but people are hard. It always seems so easy until afterwards when you find out everything you were doing wrong the whole time. I don't want to see you hurt, like I've been hurt."

Hordak slumped, at least, as far as he was able, in frustration. "I… respect your care," he said hesitantly. "But we both know I can't

remain forever in this castle, and neither can you."

Entrapta said nothing for a while. She tilted down her mask and pretended to check a couple of instruments. At last she responded, cautiously: "I promise we will discuss it later. But I need time before I'm ready. Is that okay?"

Hordak glanced at her with a smile. "Of course," he said.

Entrapta grinned behind her mask with a mixture of relief and concern. Still, there was an experiment to undertake. She shook her head and tried to focus.

"Well, are you ready?" she said at last.

"Always, for you," he replied.

Entrapta reached up with her hair to a large iron switch on the wall. "Here we go! This is going to hurt… a lot."

She pulled the switch.

"Toothbrushes," said Netossa, reading down a long, long scroll.

"Check!" said Spinnerella, picking up the item and tossing it into a large travelling trunk.

"*Spare* toothbrushes."

"Check…"

"Extra moist towelettes."

"Netty, what are we doing?" said Spinnerella.

“We’re checking to see if we have extra moist towelettes,” said Netossa. “Do you really want to spend an extra day in Bright Moon only to find out they don’t have enough towelettes? It’s everyone’s worst nightmare.”

“Darling, you know they have towelettes. We’ve barely spent a few months reclaiming the Union from what was left of the Horde. They probably have more towelettes than we do.”

Netossa gave her an impatient look. “Fine. We’ll scratch towelettes off the list. Moving on… Sleeping masks.”

“Let me have a look at that list.” Spinnerella took it from her and started reading further down the list. “Slippers. Gas medicine. Orthopaedic pillows… Oh moons, Netty, what *are* we doing.”

She sat down on the bed and rubbed her temples. Netossa sat down beside her.

“Spinny, what’s wrong? Don’t you want to go to Bright Moon?”

Spinnerella took her wife’s hand and laughed softly. “No, of course I want to go. I miss the old place already. But… are we getting, you know… *old?”*

Netossa was taken aback. “No, of course not,” she said doubtfully. “It just feels that way because we just spent half the Rebellion hanging out with a bunch of teenagers, that’s all. We’re still…” She trailed off as her eyes ran down the list. The words ‘anti-wrinkle cream’ stared back at her. “Oh moons, we really are getting old!”

They looked at each other in mild panic. Spinnerella went pale. Netossa looked like she was about to be sick.

“Alright, let’s stay calm,” said Spinnerella. “It’s not so bad. It’s not like we’re *old* old. It's not like we’re ready for the grave or anything. We’re just *comfortable,* that’s all.”

“Yeah,” said Netossa, “a little too comfortable.”

“What does that mean?”

“Oh come on, Spinny,” Netossa said. “I just spent two hours writing a packing list for week-long trip to a place we lived in for *years.* What happened to us? We used to be so spontaneous when we first started seeing each other!”

A twinkle of reminiscence shone in Spinnerella’s eyes. “Oh yes, I remember. You were such a *siren,* prowling the frontier every night. No young lady was safe from your charms.”

Netossa chuckled. “Well, I had to get your attention somehow. You were out there waging a one-woman war against the Horde. You were just so dangerous and distant, I had to be at the top of my game just so you’d notice me.”

“As if I could ever fail to notice you.”

They laughed together, and took another look at the list.

“So, what now?” asked Spinnerella. “Is this just our lives now? Just a lifetime of being comfortable? Ointments and domestic bliss until we grow old and die? It really makes you wonder what we did to deserve that fate.”

A playful smile started to form on Netossa’s lips. “It doesn’t have to be that way.”

Spinnerella narrowed her eyes. “What are you getting at?”

“Oh come on, think about it. Two strangers meeting at Bright Moon, young and carefree, locking eyes over a crowded ballroom… Perhaps a beautiful Princess could tame me from my wild ways…”

Spinnerella laughed softly. “Be serious, Netty.”

“I’m deadly serious. I’d have to be around the most feared warrior of the frontier,” said Netossa. “We’re not so past our prime yet. We can keep it fresh. When we get to Bright Moon we can just…

pretend. We just watched a bunch of kids finally figure out all their feelings for each other. Why let them have all the fun? What do you say?”

“Oh, it just seems so hokey…” said Spinnerella. A grin slowly took over her face. “But it does sounds like a lot of fun. Alright, let’s do it, but let’s do it right. No planning, we arrive separately, we stay in separate rooms. Until the party’s over we’re perfect strangers. You know how hard it is to sweep me off my feet; I’m not going to make it any easier for you.”

They embraced lovingly and laughed with nervous delight together.

“But seriously though, bring your gas powder,” said Spinnerella.

Netossa nodded. “Do you need your neck pillow?”

Spinnerella sighed. “Of course.”

Breathe

Chapter Summary

> During a meeting at Bright Moon, Adora and Catra have an argument. Glimmer and Bow take them to separate rooms to talk things out.

Adora and Catra arrived at the castle by midmorning, and while the journey had been uneventful it had been tense. To her credit, thought Adora, Catra had learned to manage her frustration surprisingly well, but the occasional twitch of her tail warned Adora that there was still a wellspring of it right below the surface.

The castle was, at least, mercifully cool. The Best Friend Squad had been unofficially superseded by what Adora thought of as the Best Friend Cabinet. As it turned out Kingdoms needed to be administered, and after the war there was just so much administering to do. Glimmer had been quick to appoint those closest to her to the most senior vacant posts, and that meant meetings, meetings and more meetings.

Only Bright Moon really didn't have much use for Adora. Yes, there was always paperwork to deal with, but the Kingdom really relied on She-Ra. She had always been a legend across Etheria, of course, but after saving the universe and her unlikely resurrection that legend had become something more; something transcendent. Her friends, for the most part, didn't treat her any differently, but their subjects did and that made all the difference.

Catra, of course, had no official role. Bow had briefly suggested making her something he called 'minister for adorableness', which Catra put to a swift and conclusive end by filling all his clothes with sand in the middle of the night. The chair—that is, Glimmer—recognised her as 'attaché to the foreign minister'. In response Catra recognised the chair as a dork.

The four of them sat around the conference table. These meetings took place once every few days and they were always the same. They shared a special kind of tedium that sometimes veered on the edge of being interesting but never quite made it over the line.

Adora looked over at Catra while Bow was speaking. She was lounging in her chair, trying and failing to feign interest. She caught Adora's eye and furtively made a funny face back.

Adora tried to hide a smile, checked to make sure no-one was looking, and stuck out her tongue in return.

Catra crossed her eyes in response, and the two of them took turns making faces at each other, giggling quietly.

"Do you have something you want to add, Adora?" said Glimmer at last.

Adora turned back to the others, who were staring at her with mild but good-natured disapproval. She took her finger out of her nose.

"No-o…" she replied slowly. "Um… The chair recognises Man-At-Arms Bow. Uh, as you were…?"

Glimmer groaned. "For the last time, *I'm* the chair, Adora. And it doesn't even work that way! Bow…"

"As I was *saying,"* said Bow, "the party plans are going well, but we've run into a handful of problems…" He activated the conference table's holographic display, which came alive with a map of the continent. "As you all know, the Kingdoms of Etheria haven't really had properly defined borders since before the days of the First Rebellion. With the threat of the Horde all the Kingdoms retreated back to their core lands, and now the war's over most of them want to go back to the way things were. Except there's a new problem. I'm not trying to point any fingers here, but *someone* magically made the whole planet lusher and

greener, and all of a sudden none of those historic borders make any sense anymore."

Everyone looked at Adora. She crossed her arms peevishly.

"Some of those rivers are better off where they are now," she said. "And a forest boundary is a stupid way to mark a border anyway."

"So what? Isn't that what your whole dumb party's meant to fix anyway?" said Catra. "To get all the Princesses together to talk about their feelings until they fix all their issues?"

"The Princesses aren't the problem," said Adora. "We've known all along that the border towns were always going to be the real trouble. They all used to be protected under the Rebellion, but these days they're looking for protection from each other. If there's going to be a lasting peace we need their co-operation. The authority of Bright Moon doesn't mean a lot out there anymore. There's only one authority they're going to respect."

Catra groaned and rolled her eyes. "Oh come *on.* There's like a hundred no-name towns around Bright Moon alone! There's no way we're taking the She-Ra tour to all of them."

"Actually, Catra, *I'm* the minister here," said Adora, "so maybe that's my decision to make."

Catra glared at her. "Oh, well pardon me for questioning the *minister!* Please forgive your humble servant!"

"Catra—" Adora began, but Glimmer made an attempt to take control of the meeting.

"You don't have to!" she said, wearily. "The leaders of the biggest towns are all invited. We just had to make some promises to convince them that it's worth their while."

"What does that mean?" asked Catra.

Adora sighed. “It means they’ll only come if She-Ra’s there.”

This caught Catra by surprise. “Y-you mean you’re going to go as She-Ra?”

“Well yeah, I guess,” said Adora. “I mean I’ll pretty much have to. It’s not like the town leaders are going to turn up to speak to regular old me.”

Catra was momentarily speechless.

“Oh no, that’s fine!” she said bitterly, leaning back in her seat. “Another evening with She-Ra… just what I wanted. I thought it’d be kind of hilarious to see you try and handle yourself at a ball when you’re not on high alert, but I’m sure I’ll find another way to entertain myself.”

“Catra, can we not do this right now?” Adora sighed.

“I’m so *tired* of all this pomp and circumstance, Adora! None of this is really us! Yes, I get it, you’re super important now or whatever and we have to go. I just…” she looked away, “…thought it wouldn’t suck if I was there with the real you.”

Adora leaned across the table and took Catra’s hand in her own. Catra looked up and met Adora’s warm smile. She couldn’t help but smile back.

“I feel the exact same way,” said Adora. “You’re probably the only person in Bright Moon who really gets it, so there’s no-one else I’d rather be there with than you. I know these past few months have been really hard for you. It’s just that everyone’s counting on She-Ra.”

They looked at each other for a moment. “Alright, fine,” mumbled Catra.

“And if it’s really that bad,” Adora continued, “you don’t have to go.”

Bow gasped and dropped his notes. Glimmer let out a quiet "Oh yikes!" under her breath.

Catra withdrew her hand, her smile replaced with a look of indignation. "I don't *have* to go? I don't *have* to? What is your problem lately!?"

Adora looked at her bewildered. "What's *my* problem?" she said, rising to her feet. *"I'm* doing my *job!* You don't always have to be there all the time!"

"Oh, so now I'm bothering you?"

"That's not what I said!"

Glimmer and Bow glanced at each other. Glimmer cleared her throat. "Of course you probably don't need to be She-Ra the *entire* time. We could—"

"You know I always try and make time for you," Adora continued, oblivious to the others. "I plan things for us to do together and you don't want to do them. But then I let you do your own thing and you're… you're always there. It's like you're *trying* to torment me!"

"Why do we always have to be doing *things* all the time?" shrieked Catra. "It's like you're always either trying to distract me or get away from me! Is it too much to ask to have my girlfriend to myself for *one single minute?"*

"Or maybe," continued Glimmer with a note of panic in her voice, "we could just negotiate with the border territories. They must want something—"

"You know what your problem is, Adora? You always have to make everything She-Ra's problem!" Catra went on. "And then it becomes *our* problem!"

"Oh, so what? I should just abandon the whole world? Sorry, Etheria," said Adora mockingly, "you're on your own now! Catra

and Adora are hermits now, apparently!”

“I’m sorry my company doesn’t do enough to satisfy that enormous ego of yours, minister!”

“And I’m sorry bringing peace to Etheria is such a burden to you all of a sudden!”

“Okay, that’s it!” cried Glimmer. “Bow, come on…”

She grabbed Bow and ~teleported~ to Adora and Catra… grasped them and ~teleported~—

—again, to some small room elsewhere in the castle.

“You two have been bickering for weeks now,” she said to Adora and Catra. “I’m calling a best friend intervention! Bow, you take Catra. Adora, you’re coming with me.”

“Wait, what?” said Bow with a look of panic in his eyes.

“Just talk to her,” said Glimmer. “We’re going to fix this.”

With a final gasp from Adora she ~teleported~ away once more.

Bow looked around the room—one of the less formal dining rooms—and then back to Catra. Catra looked back at him, stunned. It wasn’t long though before the moment passed and she let out a roar of anger. She took a blind swipe around her, knocking a stack of china from a sideboard. For good measure she picked up a glass and hurled it against the wall.

Bow watched her for a moment to make sure it was safe, took a deep breath, and took a seat. “So…” he began. Catra glowered at him. “So-o…”

Catra had never really spent any time alone with Bow. It wasn't so long ago that they were mortal enemies, and in the time since they'd really only spent time together as part of the Squad. She sat perched on a chair with her knees drawn to her chest, her tail flicking in the air, and watched him patiently.

Bow tried to avoid her gaze. He always had the feeling that Catra wasn't quite fond of him, and it wasn't like she hadn't shown signs, even after she stopped trying to kill him and all his friends. Still, she had her sweet moments. She'd softened around the edges a little… Maybe not *right now,* but still…

He got up and edged towards the side door to the larder. Catra's eyes followed him.

"What are you doing?" she asked as he opened the door.

"I don't think I can do this on an empty stomach," he replied from the larder. "How about I make us a little something."

There was a short bout of noise from the other room, and a moment later Bow emerged again with a bottle in hand.

"Hey, look what I found: milk!" He put on a wry smile. "Would kitty like some milk?"

Catra's face went pink and her ears flattened. "Don't patronise me, arrow boy!"

There was a silence. Bow's infuriating expression didn't shift a bit.

Catra looked away. "Yes," she said with a groan, "I would like the milk."

“W-why did I say something so stupid?” bawled Adora. “I’m so, so stupid! She’s just... And I’m always so... She’s just… *sniff…* always so… upset with me-e!”

Glimmer cradled Adora in her lap and gave her an occasional ‘there, there’ pat on the shoulder. She’d never seen her like this before. Sure, she and Catra had had fights—to put it mildly, she and Catra had had a war—but this time it was like something deep down inside her had just snapped. Still, Glimmer thought back to what her mother had always told her in times like this: better out than in.

A distant part of her wondered if anyone would ever guess She-Ra of all people was such a mucus-y crier.

“Okay,” she said gently. “Let it all out.”

“Every time… I think it’s going so well,” Adora said between gulps of air, “and… we just keep fighting… and I don’t knowitsnot… she’s soitswannawallnao…! Havamahhaaa-aa!”

Glimmer reached for the nearby box of tissues and pulled one out.

“Alright, look at me. Now give me a nice big blow on three. One…”

Adora blew her nose into the tissue before Glimmer could start on “two”. After filling two tissues she seemed a little calmer than before.

“She’s just so perfect,” she said through laboured breathing. “I promised her so much and I feel like I’m going insane that I can’t make good on my promises. I feel like the worst girlfriend ever and I don’t know how to fix it.”

Glimmer wiped the tears from Adora’s eyes and gave her a hopeful little smile.

“You know you’re not the ‘worst girlfriend ever’. Catra loves you. We all see it, all the time. She idolises you.”

Adora wiped her nose on her cuff. “Then why is it always going so wrong? It all seemed so perfect at first. Like nothing else in the world mattered. Like we’d really made it, you know. Like nothing would ever hurt again. But now… It just feels so complicated again…”

“Look, you’ve got to stop blaming yourself,” said Glimmer. “I mean sure, maybe you could’ve handled things a little better. But Catra… Well, sometimes she’s just Catra. I’m sure you’ve both said some things you regret. You just need a little bit of time.”

She looked at Glimmer with bloodshot eyes. “Look at me,” she said with a laugh. “I feel so stupid. I’ve never cried like this in my life. Not even when she was trying to kill me.”

“Hey, don’t worry about it. You know, I’m proud of you for letting all your feelings out for a change. The old Adora never would have. Love’s done you so much good. It’s why I believe in you two.”

Adora broke into a smile before giving her a warm hug.

“Thanks, Glimmer,” she said. It was all she could do not to start crying all over again.

“So then Adora’s all ‘Uh-uh, no, I have an obligation!’” said Catra. She refilled her glass with milk and continued, gesturing wildly with the glass in hand. “‘I’m the most important person in the universe! I have to save the whole world!’ I’m so sick of She-Ra this and She-Ra that! I mean of course I’m proud of her. She’s *amazing,* but she never switches off! It’s like she’s not really mine. The whole world gets a piece of She-Ra but not dumb old Catra. No-o! I have to practically make an appointment or something!”

Bow watched the glass, almost mesmerised at how Catra managed to avoid spilling a single drop.

"Well, have you talked to her about it?" he said.

"Of course I have! Well… not exactly 'talked'…" She stared into her glass morosely. "It's… It's not easy for me to… you know…" She looked up at him. "I've been trying to work on it. Become a better me and all that. But every time we talk it's like she just gets under my skin and… and we just start fighting… and I just can't stand it anymore! She's just so… perfect. But I always keep making everything worse, same as always!"

They drank in silence for a moment.

"I might not get *exactly* what you're going through," said Bow, "but I know what it's like when someone you love is… important."

Catra raised her eyebrows. "Oh, right, of course. It must be tough being the Queen's… uh…" She floundered for the right word. "What exactly *is* up with you two?"

"Seriously, I don't know!" said Bow. "I mean we're not exactly just friends anymore. She's made that pretty clear…" He coughed nervously into his milk. "I thought for a while it was enough that we loved each other, but I don't know…"

"Yeah, well she sure has a clear idea of where you're at," said Catra. "I can smell it on her."

"Wo-ow," said Bow as he poured them each another glass of milk. "I'm so not prepared for *that* kind of conversation. It just made a lot more sense until recently. I always knew how to be there for Glimmer, but lately everything's just a little bit… out there, you know. I guess you probably think that's pretty silly, huh?"

Catra shrugged. "Not really. You know it's hard to be that vulnerable with someone. It was pretty hard for me. I'm probably the wrong person to talk to about this, honestly. Adora and I aren't exactly the talk-it-out types. Maybe things would be easier

now if we were. We sort of just followed our instincts, if you know what I mean."

Bow leaned back and finished his drink. "It must've been pretty special. I can't imagine being so free."

Catra smirked. "You have *no* idea. It was…" She looked down into her glass and her smirk slowly faded. She blushed. "It was tender. Just sweet… and wordless, you know… Like I finally had somewhere I belonged."

"It was *so* hot," said Adora. She sat cross-legged opposite Glimmer, clutching a cushion, "you know, when we first started going out. Things just kind of… developed without words. It was just… haha, wow! Like I don't want to weird you out or anything, but I never even *imagined.* Like she'd do this thing where she'd let me brush her fur, and then—" She blushed and turned away. "Sorry, I just…"

Glimmer looked at her with an understanding grin. "You don't have to keep saying sorry. I'm not as innocent as I look. And anyway, you deserve to feel good. It makes me happy when you're happy, and you really deserve some real happiness."

"I guess it's all still a bit new," said Adora. She played with her hair nervously. "It's not something I ever thought was meant for me. I can barely process it, honestly. I guess you get it though, now that you and Bow are a whole thing now."

"Yeah…" Glimmer said with false assuredness. "Things are definitely going great alright." She groaned in frustration. "Be honest with me, Adora, I'm hot, right?"

"Oh, I, uhh…" Adora suddenly looked deeply uncomfortable.

“Things aren’t going *at all,* and I don’t know what to do! Bow’s amazing, he really is; I love him so much. But…” she groaned in frustration, “I always thought it would be different. I *needed* things to be different! I feel like I’m about ready to explode.”

“Don’t take this the wrong way,” said Adora, “but I’ve never even seen you two kiss.”

Glimmer eased a little. “Well, we… we like to keep things private,” she said bashfully. She caught Adora’s critical gaze and relented. “I know, I know! It’s all wrong! It’s just that we’ve been friends for so long. It’s just a lot scarier than I expected.” She sighed deeply. “I’m drowning out here, Adora.”

Adora took a deep breath. “I know. Believe me, it made my head hurt just thinking how close I suddenly was with my oldest friend. Somehow it felt even weirder than becoming enemies. But you don’t have to rush into anything. It’s not like you’re going anywhere, right? Trust me, when it happens it’s incredible, and so, so worth it, but give yourself some time.”

“It’s not just that,” said Glimmer. “It’s just… What if he’s not into, you know…”

Adora raised her eyebrows.

“…all this?” added Glimmer, gesturing to her body.

“Oh,” said Adora. “Oo-oh! I guess, um—” She took a moment to reset her thought process. “Look, Glimmer, you’re a beautiful woman, and you don’t need Bow or anyone to validate that for you, but I don’t think that’s going to be a problem. You two are made for each other. Maybe you two just need to talk it through so you’re both on the same page first.” Adora paused. “And maybe I should really take my own advice and talk to Catra.”

Glimmer was suddenly aware of how far she’d steered the conversation away.

"You'll be fine, really," she said. "Once you talk to her you'll both see it's not so bad."

"Yeah," sniffed Adora. "Yeah, I'll be fine. I'll just use my words. It's not like that's ever ruined everything before. I'll just walk up to her and fix everything with my mouth sounds. What's the worst that can happen?" She looked at Glimmer with panic in her eyes. "Glimmer, I'm freaking out."

Glimmer reached forward and took her hands into her hands. "Look at me," she said. "I want you to try something for me, okay? Pretend I'm Catra, and just tell me how she made you feel today."

Adora gazed at her earnest little face. She took a deep breath.

"Catra, I—" She stopped herself and went to pull away. "This is stupid."

"Adora," Glimmer said sternly, "talk to me. You opened up so much today. Don't close up on me now."

"Well maybe I hate opening up. I'm tired of everything hurting and I'm tired of all this pressure to be calm voice of reason. I know I keep screwing up, okay? I want to do better… for both of us. But you don't know how much pressure I'm under. I'm trying so hard to be everything I'm supposed to be: a diplomat, a hero, a loving partner. I keep trying and trying and it never gets any easier! It's so hard, Catra, and you just keep pushing! I love you but I just don't know how what to do. I can't promise I won't keep screwing up, but I'm never going to learn if you're never patient with me!"

She looked into Glimmer's big pink eyes, suddenly aware of what she'd just said. She began to laugh in spite of herself.

"Oh, you're *good,"* she said. "That… That feels better…"

"Well, it doesn't count until you say it to Catra. Do you think you're ready?"

Adora nodded.

“Then let’s go get her,” said Glimmer.

Bow and Glimmer stood under the courtyard veranda. Some distance away, Adora sat under the shade of a large tree and Catra, holding her arms close to herself, soon joined her.

“Bow, I’m sorry I’ve been a bit, well, *intense* lately,” said Glimmer. “It’s just I really care about what we have together. I just thought maybe if we took it further it would feel more real somehow. I was being so selfish.”

“No, you weren’t,” said Bow. “This means a lot to me too. I *want* you. I just wasn’t really prepared for just how much it was all going to be. It’s a lot, isn’t it?”

Glimmer laughed. “Yeah. Yeah, it sure is… We really are kind of messed up, huh?”

“Yeah, I guess we are,” said Bow. He turned and smiled at her. “But we can work on it.”

Glimmer took Bow’s hand. He looked at her and, to her surprise, leaned down to kiss her softly on the lips.

“Bow…!” Glimmer said at last with a blush, but without knowing what to say she leaned in for another kiss.

“Your Majesty…”

The two of them separated so rapidly that it almost looked as though Glimmer used her powers. They suddenly seemed so preoccupied with something in opposite directions from each other that the guard felt the need to begin again.

"Your Majesty, the delegation from Salineas has arrived."

"Thank you," replied Glimmer. She took a look toward Catra and Adora. Things seemed to be going well.

"Come on, Bow," she continued. "Let's give them some privacy."

Adora and Catra began by talking at the same time. For a moment there was a sea of overlapping apologies, then a silence, and then more apologies. Adora began to giggle, and the tension was gone.

"Catra, I love you so much. I don't want to keep fighting you."

Catra wiped away a tear. "I love you too. But what if we just can't stop? I feel like there's something wrong with me. You and me being a thing… it was meant to fix everything and I just can't help myself, and—"

"No, it's me. I just keep feeling so overwhelmed and I just keep ruining everything." Adora tried to remember what she'd said to Glimmer, but suddenly it felt as though hours had passed. "Like, um, I'm meant to be the voice of reason," she continued uncertainly, "and there's all these emotions. And, uh, I have to be all these things, and—"

"I'm sorry, *you're* the voice of reason?" said Catra. "So what am I? Some irrational idiot, dragging you down with my emotional baggage?"

"Catra, I— This is *exactly* what I'm talking about! I'm trying to tell you how I feel and you're always pushing!"

"Pushing? You're the one who—" Catra stopped herself and began her counting exercise. "No, you're right. I'm sorry." She started to

sob. “Adora, what are we going to do? I’m so scared I’m going to lose you.”

Adora put her arms around her. “Hey, it’s alright. You’re never going to lose me. We’re together forever, just you and me. We’ll figure this out, I promise,” she said with tears in her eyes. “I don’t want to keep hurting you.”

“You’re such an idiot,” said Catra, through tears.

They hugged tightly, and didn’t even notice the approaching figures.

“Oh wow, yeah, you totally fixed them,” said a familiar voice.

They looked up. “Mermista?” said Adora.

“Yeah, I’m here now. No need to get up or anything,” said Mermista.

Lies

Chapter Summary

> Mermista drags Adora and Catra in for couples therapy. With some hard truths finally spoken, they confront their issues of belonging.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"What are you doing here, Mermista?" said Adora. "You're early."

"Wow, okay, it's great to see you too," said Mermista. "We're here on business before the whole party thing. Glimmer invited us for some early trade talks. Seriously, trade is so booming in Salineas right now, you wouldn't believe."

Glimmer, who was standing behind her with Bow looking mortified, suddenly interjected.

"Okay, I thought Adora and Catra had had enough time, but we can just come back later," she said. "We can just get on with those trade talks. Mermista, if you'll just—"

"Are you kidding? I bought all my best treasury nerds to handle all that. Let's hang out." She threw herself onto the bench between Adora and Catra and put her arms around them. "So like what's up with you guys? Did they try the whole separate-rooms-cry-sesh thing with you or what?"

Catra had a sudden moment of realisation. She peered at her inquisitively. "No way… Are you telling me they tried that on you and that weird sailor boy of yours too?"

Glimmer gave them all an embarrassed smile.

"Ugh, as if," said Mermista. "I mean if they did it definitely wouldn't work anyway. No-one ever fixed anything by crying about it. You guys need couple's therapy or something. Lucky for you I just so happen to be a qualified couple's therapist. It's not a big deal or anything."

Catra's inquisitive peer transformed into an incredulous glare. "What? Qualified by who?"

"I don't know. Like the… Mermista School of… of Romantic… Psychology, okay? Get off my case!" She looked out towards the courtyard entrance and yelled: *"Sea Hawk!"*

A moment later Sea Hawk came running from inside like an eager puppy. *"Yee-ees, my swee-eet!"* he called out.

"Ugh, no, stay inside," said Mermista, shooing him away. "Hook up our trade guys with Twinkle's trade guys. And hold all my meetings. I'm going to be busy."

She grabbed Adora and Catra and began gently ushering them inside. They were too stunned to protest.

"I'm going to need a room with therapy stuff," she said to Glimmer. "Something with a one of those couches you lie on and talk about your dreams and stuff." She paused as inspiration struck. "No… *two* of those couches!"

"Mermista," began Glimmer, pinching the bridge of her nose, "you can't just play therapist! Let them talk it out together. They've got this."

"Oh, *I* can't play therapist? 'Oh Mermista, let out all your feelings. Tell me how you really feel about Sea Hawk.' It wasn't that simple for us and it's not going to be that simple for them. I am *not* going to see another beautiful couple tear each other apart, and especially not because you think the power of love is going to magically fix everything." She turned back to Adora and Catra. "Come on, you two. Let's show these guys how it's done."

Catra pulled away. “Don’t we get a sa—”

“No!” snapped Mermista. “This is happening!”

And with that, Mermista, Catra and Adora vanished into the castle.

As the ‘treasury nerds’ took their places Bow shuffled into the gallery and took a seat next to Sea Hawk, crossing his arms irritably.

“Bow! So good to see you again,” said Sea Hawk. “What’s wrong, old friend? You seem glum.”

“Be honest with me: do any of us really have our whole deals together well enough to start giving relationship advice?”

Sea Hawk thought about it for a second. “Probably not. But my Mermista… oh-o, you’d be surprised. She’s something else entirely! She’s… really, *really* entirely the wrong person to start dishing out advice, actually. But hey, who do we have but each other, right?”

Bow shrugged. After a moment he looked up.

“Is that... Spinnerella?” he said. “All by herself? I don’t think I’ve ever seen that before.”

He waved her over. A moment later she sat with them both and they exchanged pleasantries.

“Where’s Netossa?” asked Bow at last. “I don’t think I’ve ever seen the two of you apart.”

Spinnerella opened her mouth to answer, but then changed her demeanour as though she’d suddenly remembered something.

She leant back in her seat. “You must have me confused with someone else. I’ve never heard that name before,” she said with a wry smile. “I’m… distant… and dangerous…”

Bow put up his hands in exasperation. “Not getting into *that.* It’s cool, everyone around me is just crazy now. I can live with that.”

He sat back and closed his eyes. He’d just heard Sea Hawk begin with, “funny you should mention that… Some say I’m also distant and dangerous,” when a sudden worrying gurgle from his stomach made shook him back into alertness.

“Oh no,” he said. “I shouldn’t have had all that milk.”

“What just happened?” said Catra. “Where did all this stuff come from?”

It was like a spell had suddenly worn off. Somehow Mermista had secured a cosy and quiet parlour, with a plush armchair for herself and, yes, two therapy couches.

“I don’t know,” said Adora. “It’s probably best just to go along with it. You know Mermista.”

Catra turned on her couch to face her. Since the two were angled very slightly away from each other this involved sitting up and rotating her whole torso. “No, I don’t! We’ve spent half a year travelling Etheria for boring meetings. When would I ever get to know anyone? Why do you always think I know everyone like you know them?”

“Oh, don’t you remember?” said Mermista. “I’m the one whose Kingdom you subjugated and plundered. It was kind of a big deal at the time.”

Catra stared at her for a moment, and looked down in shame. She was trying to find the words to say when Adora suddenly cut in.

"That's uncalled for—" she began.

"You know what, no," Mermista cut her off. "We're going to have some real talk. We're done with Glimmer's hand-holdy 'kiss and make up' nonsense. No excuses, no apologies."

"Alright, that's enough," said Adora. "Why are you doing this?"

"Because I'm trying to help you guys," said Mermista. "Trust me, okay, I've been through all this myself. All the little lies you tell yourselves and each other every day? Trust me, I know all the signs. I'm like the champion of lying about feelings, okay. You're not going to pull one over on me." She turned back to Catra. "But for real don't worry about it. You're not forgiven, obviously. Not even close. But we can move past it. I can respect you, one bad bitch to another. We can even be friends. But you're not forgiven. Not yet, anyway."

Catra said nothing.

"So, trouble in paradise, huh?" Mermista went on. "I've so been there. You know I just see like so much of me in you. You guys are super dark deep down. It's a whole lot to process."

"We're not 'super dark'," protested Adora. "We're just going through a rough patch. We'll get over it."

"It's not a 'rough patch', Adora," said Catra. "I think she's right. Things haven't been getting better; they've been getting worse. There's something wrong between us."

"Oh, come *on!* Someone you barely know withholds forgiveness from you one time and you instantly think she's got all the answers, even though she's *obviously* underqualified? No offence, Mermista."

“Um, a bit taken, actually,” said Mermista. “I’m sensing a lot of anger here. Adora, it sounds like you resent Catra trying to reach out to you. Why don’t you tell us both why that is? Don’t mind me if I make notes or whatever.”

Adora glowered at her. “I don’t ‘resent’ her, okay? We’re doing great. So, so great. I mean yeah, we’ve had a few little *tiffs,* but maybe that’s just because *someone* apparently loves being the villain.”

“Hey, I do not!” said Catra, her tail suddenly standing like a bottlebrush.

“Come on, Catra, you know it’s true,” said Adora. “I love you so much and it’s killing me that you keep putting a wall between yourself and the world. You’ve always been like this, ever since we were kids. Back then it made sense that it was just you and me, but everyone’s working so hard to make you feel accepted and included now, and you just… refuse to be a part of it! It can’t just be us against the world anymore, Catra. I can’t go back to that and I don’t want you to either. We deserve a place in the world.”

“Wow, okay, it feels like we’re really getting somewhere,” said Mermista, doodling a seahorse into her notebook. “Catra, do you want to respond to that?”

“Yeah, actually. Adora, it—”

Catra tried turning on the couch to face her directly again and immediately lost her patience with the frustrating arrangement. With a growl of frustration she got up and dragged hers to face the other way.

“Adora,” she began again, “it’s not the same for me. You’re a Princess! What do you know about having a place in the world? I didn’t get a stupid tiara or a big shiny sword, but you know what? I was *someone* in the Horde… Heck, I was your equal! And now I’m, what? Your attaché? When did I ever get the chance to be the hero?”

The words hit Adora like a punch to the gut. “What are you talking about? Catra, you’re *my* hero. I can’t tell you how many ways you’ve saved me.”

“Oh, that’s such a *line.* You’re the *world’s* hero, Adora. I thought it would be so easy, just you and me, but it’s not. I really thought as soon as we were finally together everything would just make sense, but it hasn’t made sense for such a long time. The world has a place for you that it will never have for me, and that means everywhere we go there’s always *her.”*

Mermista looked up from her notebook. “Hey, I’m just trying to help.”

“Not you!” hissed Catra. “I meant She-Ra, obviously! It’s like there’s three of us in this relationship and I… I can’t compete with She-Ra. I mean who am I without the Horde?”

Adora looked away, unable to respond. Mermista tried to put the thought that Catra without the Horde was, in fact, the best kind of Catra to the back of her mind and tapped her pencil on the edge of her notepad.

“Wow, that was so super intense and emotional and stuff,” she said. “We’re making so much progress today. So, Adora, how about this whole She-Ra thing? Everyone tells me you’re She-Ra like all the time these days. What’s up with that?”

Adora looked at her incredulously. “I’m what Etheria needs me to be.” she said severely. “I’m doing everything everyone’s asking me to do. And you know what, I know I’m not perfect. I know I say all the wrong things sometimes. But it’s not like I’m the only one. It’s one thing talking with Glimmer and Bow and their not-so-secret-secret-relationship, but *you,* Mermista? You and Sea Hawk are the most dysfunctional couple I know.”

“Well yeah, but I don’t even like Sea Hawk all that much,” said Mermista.

That was too much for both of them to accept. There was a moment where Catra and Adora spoke over each other before Catra broke through with: "…we R.S.V.P.'d to your wedding!"

Mermista casually hid her engagement ring behind her notebook.

"What does that have to do with anything?" she said.

The others stared at her in disbelief.

"What happened to real talk?" said Catra. "Seriously, is everything okay? With you and what's-his-name?"

Mermista rolled her eyes.

"Ugh! Look, it's actually none of your business, but yeah, okay, we both kinda suck sometimes—especially Sea Hawk. He really, really sucks." She looked away. "Alright, I guess that's not fair. I'm the one who really, really sucks. I suppose I should be honest with you guys—things are tough, and it's all my fault."

"What do you mean?" said Catra.

"I know you guys get it," said Mermista with a sigh. "We're not like the other Princesses, right? We have *demons.* The Horde never taught you how to let anyone into your heart, and my parents sure didn't teach me. I've got a whole lot of bad memories from back then and this whole stupid party thing is just bringing so many back. I guess that's why I've sucked more than normal lately," she continued, more to herself than to Adora and Catra. "You know, for a long time I used to think love meant finding someone who didn't totally suck, but we all suck. Sometimes love is just finding someone who sucks in a way that works with how you suck. And I've dated some people who *really* sucked."

"Wow, you said 'suck' just… so many times," said Adora.

"Wait, what do you mean you 'dated' people?" said Catra. "What does 'dated' mean?"

Mermista snapped her pencil in half. "What do you *mean*, 'what does that mean'? Is this another one of those weird Horde things, like when you didn't know what moisturiser was? Ugh, why are you ex-Horde people so *weird?* It's like… it's like when you kind of like someone a little bit to see if you actually like them a whole lot, I guess?"

This explanation didn't appear to help.

"Like… having friends?" asked Adora.

"No! Well, sort of, but more, I guess? Seriously, did neither of you ever date anyone before each other? No past girlfriends or anything?"

The pair of them looked at each other again. Adora shrugged.

"I don't think so?" said Catra.

Mermista looked at her notebook, sighed, and threw it in the waste bin.

"No wonder you're both like this," she said. "You've never had an intense relationship before. You think it's all meant to be rainbows and cinnamon kisses and stuff and because that's what love *always* feels like the first time. You both think the other one is perfect, but really you both totally suck. No offence."

"A bit taken, actually," Adora muttered.

Catra spoke up. "That's ridiculous. I do *not* think she's perfect."

"Yeah, you do," said Mermista. "And I can tell because you want to be perfect for her. So there's this idea called displacement, right? It's like when you substitute your feelings for one thing onto something else. So like you think Adora's totally perfect because you're all smoochy around her, but you don't think you're good enough. Never the hero, right? But She-Ra actually *is* basically perfect, right? I mean she's super strong, saved the universe… those *thighs,* amazing hair…"

“Mermista…” began Adora, wearily.

“…So instead of being threatened by Adora you’re threatened by She-Ra,” she continued without missing a beat. “You’re not seeing Adora for who she really is because you don’t have the benefit of experience. You’re reconciling it with a bunch of dumb ideas about She-Ra but that’s never been the problem. And if you just talked to your girlfriend like a person for once you’d see that you don’t have to compete with anyone.”

Catra stared at her in wonderment. After a moment all she could say was “Whoa.”

“I read a bunch of books,” said Mermista with a shrug. “It’s not like it’s that complicated.”

Adora coughed politely.

“Okay, but that doesn’t work on me. I mean Catra doesn’t do the whole *whoosh-psshew!* thing, so this doesn’t really apply to me, does it?”

“Well it kinda does if you think about it for like half a second,” said Mermista thoughtfully. “Catra’s right: you’re always trying to be the hero and it’s all because you don’t think you’re as good as She-Ra. You spent like the whole war trying to be everyone’s hero, okay. Why would you think you’re over it now? Don’t think you’re not every bit as messed up this one here.”

“That’s not the same thing.”

“Isn’t it? You put Catra on a pedestal so high you have to be eight feet tall to reach it. I’m a Princess too; I’ve been there, believe me! You think you have to be her perfect magical girlfriend, but you *don’t.* You get mad whenever she tries to bring you down to her level because you still don’t think you’re worthy.”

Adora sat in silence and stared at her hands.

"Seriously, you dinguses, you're totally worthy. I have to believe that. I mean if you're not, then are any of us, really? Like am I?"

"Well, um—" began Adora nervously.

"Like it's scary when you feel like you're just going to mess it up all over again," continued Mermista. "You just get so used to pushing everyone away and suddenly it's like 'oh wait, I guess things are serious now; that's something.' It's so easy to just go back to putting up walls again, all because deep down you just never thought any of this would happen to you. But like maybe it doesn't matter if you never planned for love, right? It's still a lot better than the alternative."

Catra looked at Adora in mild confusion, and then back to Mermista.

"Are we still talking about us?" she said.

"Listen, do you want to know something about me and Sea Hawk?" Mermista said, leaning forward conspiratorially. "There's no-one on Etheria I'd rather spend the rest of my life with *because* he's just so… well, you've met him. I'm… I'm awful sometimes, you have no idea. I'm every bit my dad's daughter… for better or worse…" She sighed deeply. "But Sea Hawk sees it every single day and worships me because of who I am, not because of who he imagines I am. I know it's real with him, and he knows it's real with me."

She took a moment to compose herself, and looked at Catra and Adora for a moment.

"Look, all I'm saying is just talk to each other. I guess it's natural or whatever to get these stories in your head about other people… or about yourself. Maybe if you talk about it you'll realise all your insecurities aren't actually what's driving you apart at all—they're what make you work together. It took me a long time to figure that one out… I guess I still am, really."

Adora and Catra gazed at each other in a shared moment of sobering vulnerability. It was over almost as soon as it started. They turned away from each other and buried that feeling a little inside.

"And by the way," continued Mermista, "if you tell anyone what I just told you I will *destroy* you. Don't think I don't mean it. I don't care how good your wedding gifts are."

After Adora and Catra had left, Mermista sat in the parlour for a while. She fixed herself a drink and laid on one of the couches, listening to the sounds of the castle around her. Eventually she heard the door open behind her.

"Hey, babe," she said to Sea Hawk, without turning around. "How did it go with the trade talks?"

Sea Hawk threw himself onto the other couch and reclined gracefully. "Oh, as well as expected, my Princess, but can anything truly be perfect without you? Also we're actually having some problems without you. Queen Glimmer's still running a hard line on sea grain tariffs and we need you down there."

Mermista didn't move. "It can wait for a bit; I need a minute. Seriously, those two walking disaster areas? Like just wow. It's like looking into a mirror. I've been such a screw-up recently. I honestly don't know why you put up with it."

"It's my sworn duty to serve, either by sword or by pen! But I actually just spent most of the last hour taking care of Bow. Did you know he's lactose intolerant? Someone must've slipped the poor lad a gallon of milk or something, because, hah, he just couldn't stop—"

Mermista laughed. “That’s not what I meant, you goober! Look, I’m sorry I’ve been so distant lately. I thought I was over it all when I asked you to marry me, like everything was finally going to make sense. I guess I just can’t believe I get to have all this.”

Sea Hawk stood up and knelt by her side. He took her hand in his. “I’ll forever be glad I have the honour of seeing you as you are, with everything that comes with it. Take some of your own advice for once: you don’t have to be perfect to be perfect to me.”

“I guess I’m just scared of hurting you.”

“We’ve both hurt, my sweet. Getting to hurt with you… well, that just makes me the luckiest old sea dog in the world.”

She wiped away a single tear and blushed.

“Oh whatever. Get over here and kiss me already.”

It was already late by the time Catra and Adora headed back to the cottage. They ate a small meal and talked for hours until it was dark. Catra taught Adora her small ritual of counting to ten, which helped a bit. Adora spoke at length about what it felt like *not* being She-Ra, and Catra, in a roundabout way, did the same. They laughed about how stupid it was that they had this beautiful, flawless third party in their lives. Once it was dark they laid on the rooftop in the sweltering heat, hand in hand, and stared at the stars.

“That stupid Princess party actually does mean a lot to me,” Catra confessed at last. “I know it's not a big deal or anything, but I was really looking forward to going with you. With Adora, I mean. The second I first heard about it I got so excited. I’ve never…”

She trailed off. Adora squeezed her hand.

“I’ve never felt like a part of your world,” Catra continued in a whisper. “I thought maybe this was finally my way in—a chance to really be a part of things. Honestly, I don’t know how you do it. A few years ago neither of us knew what a *horse* was, and now you’re the guest of honour at a *ball.* Don’t you ever think of how crazy that is?”

“But I’m still the same as I always was, Catra—at least with you,” said Adora. “She-Ra’s a part of this world, but I’m not. I’m still just Horde scum, same as you.’

“No, that’s not true,” said Catra. “You’re different now, Adora. You’ve actually changed a lot. You’re better. I just thought maybe I could be different with you. You and me… just belonging for once, together in the middle of all of it.”

“You don’t think you’ll belong with She-Ra?” said Adora.

“I don’t think I belong anywhere,” said Catra. “Except with Adora. It’s been a long time since everything just lined up, you know. Everything fell apart so quickly when you left the Horde, and when I got you back everything else was gone. I know it was so, so awful, all the time, but sometimes I miss it. Nowhere since has really been home.”

They lay in silence and stared at the moons. Soon after they drifted into a fitful sleep.

Chapter End Notes

Needless to say, Mermista is not a therapist and neither am I.

This was a tough chapter to edit. I'd just like to say thank you to everyone who's given this little story a read. It really means the world to me.

Faith

Chapter Summary

> Adora travels with Bow to Dryl to check on Entrapta while Catra remains behind. They have some illuminating conversations with Hordak and Entrapta.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The next morning they once again found themselves back in Bright Moon. They had to admit that the comings and goings of the busy castle was a welcome distraction, and as they made their way through the halls they saw a handful of familiar faces. Mermista and Sea Hawk seemed to be getting along in a way Adora had never seen before, holding hands and laughing together, although she suspected they'd stop if she interrupted them. For a moment Adora felt a little guilty for calling them dysfunctional, but that thought was quickly knocked out of her mind when they bumped into Netossa on their way into Glimmer's office.

"Netossa," said Adora. "So good to see you. Is Spinnerella with you?"

"Spinnerella? I can't say that name rings a bell," she said performativity. Adora and Catra exchanged glances. "But if I see her I'll probably break her heart. That's just the kind of thing a heartbreaker like me does. See you both at the party."

And with that, she disappeared down the corridor.

"Don't take this the wrong way," said Catra, "but all your friends are crazy."

They opened the door to Glimmer's office and went inside. Glimmer looked up at them from behind a heavy stack of

paperwork.

“Hi, Adora. Hi, Catra,” she said. “Have a seat.”

“Did you just speak to Netossa?” asked Adora. “What’s going on there?”

Glimmer shrugged. “She and Spinnerella have been acting weird since they arrived, acting like they don’t even know each other. They won’t tell me why. It’s sort of weirding everyone out, honestly, but they seem to be having fun. Anyway, we have a real problem—have either of you heard from Entrapta lately?”

“Not in months. I think the last time we saw her was Scorpia’s birthday,” said Catra. “But you know Entrapta. She’s probably just busy building something that will end the world someday. She’ll turn up eventually.”

“Yeah, I’m sure she’s fine,” said Adora. “Just fine, with Hordak, which is definitely not something I’m constantly worried about.”

Glimmer seemed unconvinced. “It’s been too long, even for Entrapta. Something’s up, and I don’t know what. Honestly, I feel like a bad friend; we should’ve checked in ages ago, but there’s just been so much going on. But now this is a diplomatic problem. I’m sure none of us exactly feel great about the whole Hordak situation, right? I mean it’s the eve of a huge event and there’s potentially a rogue Kingdom right on our doorstep. I think we have to treat this one pretty carefully.”

“Of course,” said Adora. She recognised that tone. She looked over at Catra, who was entertaining herself by idly crafting an origami bird out of some extremely official-looking sheet of correspondence and felt a sudden pang of guilt. “This sounds like you need She-Ra to pay a little visit.”

“I just need Bright Moon represented in Dryl,” said Glimmer. “This is really just Entrapta being Entrapta, but just check that she’s okay. And you know, it wouldn’t hurt to lay down a little of that

ministerial authority. Get her to come to the party. Maybe She-Ra's enough to get her out of isolation."

Glimmer snatched the paper bird from Catra before the two of them left.

Wordlessly, Adora made her way to the castle gate, walking fast enough that even Catra found it hard to keep up with her through the crowded corridors. It wasn't until they'd hurried into the grounds that Catra broke the silence.

"Alright," she said, "it's time to stop being weird. I know what this is about. You think I'm going to fly off the handle because, once again, perfect, perfect She-Ra has to save the day."

"Well, you don't sound too thrilled about it," said Adora, quickening her pace.

"Yeah, no kidding! You know it bothers me. And maybe that's on me, but it does," said Catra. "But I'm not *mad* anymore. I'm not going to give you a hard time about it. So will you just stop and look at me!"

Catra gripped her hand and Adora spun round. To Catra's surprise she was holding back tears. Instinctively, Catra pulled her into a tight embrace and stroked her hair.

"Hey, what's wrong?" said Catra. "I thought I was the one who was meant to get stupid about this stuff."

Adora pressed her head against Catra's and took in the scent of her hair.

"I was just hoping that maybe it would all work out without She-Ra. Etheria's become so dependent on her… but worst of all so have I. Mermista was right: I'm still afraid to just be Adora with you. All this time we've had together, ever since the Heart… For all these months I've never been *just* Adora… I've been letting you down, all because I'm just scared."

Catra pulled back and kissed her softly.

“You’ve never let me down,” she said. “Even when I’ve been angry I’ve never once felt let down. Why would you be scared?”

Adora looked into Catra’s eyes, then pulled away.

“Because I abandoned you, Catra! I never stopped feeling guilty. I thought once we were together again the guilt would go away, but somehow every time I hold aloft that stupid sword I feel like I’m abandoning you all over again. During the war She-Ra felt so necessary, but now I just feel like she takes me away from really being with you. But the worst part is when I’m her I just don’t feel guilty anymore. You were right all along: there’s two of us, and the more I’m her the less I’m with you.”

Catra moved closer. “Then you don’t have to be her anymore. The war’s over. You can give her up. Why don’t we just go to Dryl together? Just Catra and Adora, on our own little mission. It’s not like Entrapta’s going to care how tall you are.”

“It’s not that simple. It’s not about the transformation; she’s with me all the time now. We’re inseparable. She’s there whenever I hold up the seal of Bright Moon. Every time I go out into the world I’m She-Ra, at least a little bit. I’ve never been a part of anything without her—not the Rebellion, not as Glimmer’s minister, not when I’m rebuilding Etheria—except when all I had was you. I’ve never had to be She-Ra to be with you. When we’re alone I feel like it’s the only space where I’m truly Adora, and I miss it. I’ve been missing it for a while now.”

“Then don’t go to Dryl,” pleaded Catra. “It can just be you and me, like it used to be. There’s still one last place out there where we can just have each other. We don’t need the world.”

Adora looked at Catra with a mournful smile and placed her hand on her cheek. Catra closed her eyes and leaned in to her gentle touch.

“You need the world, Catra,” said Adora. “I know you think you don’t have a place out here, but you have no idea how much stronger and better you’ve become as part of it. And I guess I have a place too, and that means sometimes I need to be She-Ra. For now, at least.”

Catra took Adora’s hand and moved it over her heart. She held it there a second, and the two looked into each other’s eyes. Finally, Catra let go.

“Then I’ll stay here and wait for you. Go and be She-Ra. And when you’re back, maybe we can just spend some time without her.”

A single tear rolled down Adora’s face. She let out a resigned laugh, and then leaned down and kissed Catra one more time.

She took a few steps back, then turned and left the castle.

In Catra’s absence Bow had agreed to go with Adora. The journey to Dryl was uneventful and more than a little awkward. Adora said little and Bow wisely kept to himself, but by the time they sighted Crypto Castle he felt he had to say something.

“Is it just me, or is it getting a little Fright Zone-y around here?”

He was right. Although the Kingdom had, like all of Etheria, become slightly greener of late, the few support buildings around the base of the castle’s peak had been expanded, and there was a certain familiar feeling to the new architecture. It was uncomfortably silent.

“Well, I guess we should be prepared for anything,” said Adora. She summoned the Sword.

"Adora, maybe Catra was right," said Bow, seeing the anxiety in Adora's face. "You don't need to be She-Ra anymore. Whatever's going on in Dryl, we can deal with it without her."

Adora closed her eyes and held the sword to the sky, and continued her transformation.

Soon after they stood in the dark entrance hall. It was more than a little messier than they remembered it. A few tiny robots scuttled about, cleaning up some colossal mess of scrap and notes and moving it, with machine efficiency, to the opposite side of the room where a different set of tiny robots set about moving it back again. She-Ra took a step forward.

"Entrapta!" she called out. Her voice echoed. "Emily! Uh… Wrong Hordak?" She paused, unsure if she wanted to keep working down the list. "Hor—"

"So it is!" rang Hordak's voice from the shadows. Bow froze behind She-Ra.

"Ah, old enemies re-united again!" continued Hordak, stepping out of darkness. "Adora… and…" he looked at Bow and hesitated for a moment. "…and Spare Number Two. Come in. She's not expecting you, but I have had her summoned. Follow!"

They followed Hordak to a near-identical room on the second level. Bow made a conscious effort to stand behind She-Ra at all times. In principle everyone knew that Hordak was no longer a threat, but his long absence in Dryl and his general Hordak-ness made it a little hard not to see him as the tyrant he once was. Still, there was something different about Hordak. Bow had expected him to still look like all the other Prime clones, but the mark of Entrapta's tinkering was evident. Still, there was something else…

"Hordak, are you growing a moustache?" he said.

"And what of it?" snapped Hordak. "I…" His voice softened. "Entrapta has encouraged me to set myself apart from the *other*

one. What better reminder of my new individuality when I look in the mirror than a thick, full moustache. Perhaps you should consider the same. It would suit your face."

They peered at the fine whisp of thin, spider-like hairs adorning his upper lip. Bow and She-Ra shared a glance.

"So… Hordak," began She-Ra, "keeping busy with the whole individuality thing? That must be a nice distraction from, uh, any lingering ambitions to conquer Etheria."

Bow nudged her in the ribs, but Hordak didn't appear to pick up on her concern.

"It has not been easy," he said. "Sometimes I feel I do not know who I am. I have a strange recollection, Adora, of the mind of Horde Prime. Through the eyes of another I have watched you struggle as I have struggled. To be one when you have been two, or many… I wonder if you have made as much progress as I… Ah! At last. Would either of you care for tea?"

A small robot crawled into the room and onto a table. It carefully placed down three ceramic cups and filled them with a viscous dark liquid. Bow recoiled, but She-Ra stepped forward and took a cup. With a look at Hordak she took a sip. It was disgusting, like bitter syrup. In a strange way it tasted like home.

"Hordak, what's going on here?" she asked. "No-one's seen Entrapta for months, the castle's a mess. Have you two really been shut in here for months? What have you been doing?"

Hordak laughed. "Oh, I have no desire to distance ourselves from the world. Quite the opposite. Perhaps you should speak to Entrapta. Ah, here she is now…"

Suddenly the far wall split open with a hiss of steam. Entrapta sat on the other side a small and crowded lab, and her eyes lit up when she saw them.

"Oh *wowww,* you're actually here! Adora! Bow!" She rushed towards them and gave them both a tight hug. "I'm so happy to see you! It's been too long! What's it been? A month?"

"It's been five months!" said Bow, gasping for air. "We thought something happened to you. Everyone's been trying to contact you."

"Oh. Well I haven't had much time to catch up with my messages. I've been busy. Come on, I'll show you what I've been working on," said Entrapta. "Hordak, would you excuse us."

She half-lead, half-dragged Bow and She-Ra into the other room. The wall behind them closed again with a loud clunk.

"You see, after we got back *from space* I just couldn't get anything done," she said, suspending herself in the middle of the room and fiddling with a cluster of levers. "I don't know if you noticed but Hordak's a little out of sorts lately, what with the whole brain thing. He kinda needed his own space. *Ahaha!* Hold on!"

She slammed her palm on a large button and there was a sudden jolt of movement.

"So anyway, I thought so what? I can just have two labs. But then Wrong Hordak just comes and goes all the time, like he does, and I couldn't do *three* labs, so anyway—"

There was another jolt of movement and the wall opened, again, into a different room.

"I turned my lab into an elevator!" Entrapta cackled gleefully, pushing the others out into the new room. "And it goes sideways! It goes *upside-down!* With a few more modifications I'll never have to leave it behind anywhere! Now, where did I put that throne...? I have some tiny snacks in the lab if you want any. I can go back and get them if you want. Ah, here we go!"

She swiped a bundle of sheet metal off an ancient, rusting iron throne and sat in it. "So this is an official visit, right? I noticed you're busy being tall."

She-Ra coughed politely, slightly unnerved by Entrapta's unblinking stare. "Um, okay… Princess Entrapta," she began, recovering her most official tone of voice, "I come to you as an envoy of Bright Moon on behalf of Glimmer, Qu—"

"That's *awesome!"* yelled Entrapta. "So cool, so official. Hey, do you still hang around with Catra? Is she still trying to kill you?"

She-Ra sighed. "Yeah, maybe a bit. Listen, Entrapta, I hate to make this so formal but we're here on business…"

"And because we were all worried about you," added Bow. "No-one's heard from you in so long. Everyone's been worried something terrible might've happened."

"But also that's sort of the whole point. Glimmer's doing this whole diplomatic event thing—well, it's a party, I guess—because we're all losing touch so fast now the Rebellion is over. It means a lot to her to have all the Princesses there, for the peace of Etheria. But most of all because you're our friend."

Entrapta appeared to think it over for a second.

"No thanks," she said with a shrug. "It all sounds a little like Princess stuff. That's never really been my thing."

"But you went to Princess Prom, and that was all the way in the Kingdom of the Snows," said Bow. "This is practically next door, and I promise it's going to be totally stress-free."

"Yes, totally stress-free," said She-Ra. "It's been a nightmare of emotions for me, personally, but that's another matter entirely."

"I don't know…" said Entrapta. Her voice was suddenly marked by a hint of uncertainty. "I've been really busy recently…"

“It’ll be fun. How often does a good social experiment come along? Besides, I don’t mean to be personal but it really looks like you could do with getting outside of these walls. It’s a bit of a mess in here. I mean five months is a long time to be alone.”

This caught Entrapta off-guard. “I’m not alone. The castle’s never been more full of life. And it’s not just robots this time! We have a little family here now—everything I ever wanted. I don’t need to go all the way to Bright Moon for that.”

“Well, I didn’t mean—”

“No, I’d better get back to work…” said Entrapta, as she got up and began to make her way back to her lab. “I’ll get Emily to show you out…”

There was a crack in her voice as she spoke. A sudden look of panic betrayed her.

“Entrapta, what’s wrong?” pleaded She-Ra. “You can always talk to us. We’re your friends. You can stay here if you really want, or come back to Bright Moon with us, but if something’s wrong we can help. I promise.”

Entrapta looked back at her. She put her face in her hands and shook her head.

“It’s not that,” she said. “I’m not the one who’s unhappy, Hordak is! I’ve just been messing everything up lately. This is the first time in my life I haven’t been able to fix things with science, and I don’t know what to do.”

Entrapta’s voice became smaller as she spoke, and as She-Ra reached out to her the transformation ended and she was Adora once again. Bow pulled them both into a tight hug, and a moment later Entrapta wrapped her hair around them and gave them a loving squeeze.

They sat in a comfortable corner of Entrapta's lab. Although she was quiet at first she soon became her normal animated self, and began to speak at length.

"It really seemed perfect once we returned to Etheria," she was saying. "I can't put my finger on where things started going wrong. I mean I've never really had so many people so close in my life before. I used to be pretty good at being alone, but all of a sudden we were a family here: my Hordaks, Emily… I thought it'd be fun. Peace, seclusion, twenty-five thousand feet of copper wire… It's what every little girl dreams about, right? But I guess I was just being silly. It's just not working out at all."

Adora wasn't sure where to begin, but she tried anyway. "Are you really saying you and Hordak are in trouble? I mean you're just both so…" She paused and tried again. "I mean if ever anyone was going to… Uh…" She gave up and continued bluntly. "Listen, Entrapta, none of us have ever got what you see in that guy. You know I was raised to fear him? When I was a kid the biggest celebration of the year was something we called the Day of Pain. They told us that unless we'd been good all year he'd put bits of metal in our food."

Bow gawked at her. "How does your life still have *even more* tragic details?"

"Oh yeah, I can see that," said Entrapta. "But he's come so far since then! He's improving at an exponential rate—nineteen percent more sensitive, thirty-two percent more sweet! He takes me for *walks.* He's become a horticulturalist. Just look at the flowers he grew for me."

She gestured to a vase full of sick, dying weeds steeped in foul brown water.

"Wow, they look amazing," said Adora.

"He helps me with my lab work. He's been helping me run Dryl. He's been learning to paint. Every Friday night we used to go to bed early and he did just *unbelievable—"*

Adora felt the urgent need to interrupt. "So what's the problem? That all sounds great."

Entrapta looked frustrated. "Oh you don't understand! That's great for a science experiment, but that's not all he is. I've… Wow, I've been this close to anything that wasn't just a source of stats and data. I'm way out of my depth here."

Bow looked extremely confused. "So is Hordak, like, your…?"

He gestured at her to finish the sentence.

"Yes, I suppose he is," said Entrapta. "He's growing all the time and at first it was *fascinating* at first. The data I've collected on the nature of the Horde hive mind from his re-networked neurons will take a lifetime to process. Ooh, we used to talk for hours about it! All we needed for the perfect night in was six thousand volts surging through his tender neocortex, a romantic dinner and a detailed analysis of the anomalous neurological form fluctuations in comparison to a control brain… But that was before. He's restless and it's getting worse all the time. We don't even talk about lab work most days; he has no scientific projects of his own anymore; he wants to go *outside* now. I can't keep up with how much he's changing."

"Well everyone changes sometimes," said Bow. "I kinda get it though. It can be a little overwhelming."

"Well, I'm not sure I do. I *love* science! It's what brought us so close in the first place, but now he's just going through the motions. I'm used to people getting fed up with it and going away, but I just don't know if I could handle that with Hordak. What if he doesn't need me anymore? There's a whole world out there offering him everything I can't! No, no, we have to stay right here until I formulate some kind of plan."

Adora looked at Bow, and then at Entrapta. She sighed, weighed down by the knowledge of exactly what she had to say.

"Entrapta," she said, "you're being an idiot."

Adora expected her to be upset by this, but Entrapta looked at her with fascination. "Interesting! No-one's ever said that to me before. Continue."

"It's not a bad thing when people change, Entrapta," said Adora. "Especially not Hordak. It doesn't mean he doesn't want you in his life anymore. We all change all the time, and it's pretty scary sometimes. Relationships are hard, and confusing, and so, so upsetting…"

Entrapta gave her a frustrated look. "This doesn't sound encouraging."

"Look, you can't just lock yourselves up in this castle forever," said Adora. "We came here thinking he was doing that to you, but you're right: it sounds like he's really, really changed. I mean he offered us tea. Back in the Fright Zone the only thing to drink was a nutrient-rich broth. They called it 'secretion' and I never found out why."

"Just… wow…" murmured Bow.

"My point is, *you* did that, Entrapta. *You* changed him. I'm pretty convinced he's still a little bit evil, but it's all your love and care that's made him into something better than he used to be. You're changing too. I remember when you didn't have a single real friend, and now here you are with a family that means so much to you that you're afraid to risk letting them go."

Entrapta looked down at the floor. "Ooh but that's not the same thing. You know how hard it is for me, out there. It's just that for a while everything finally seemed to make sense, and now I just don't know anymore. It's strange, and I know it was awful, but the last time I really felt like everything was right was when we were in the Fright Zone."

Adora couldn't help but laugh. "You know Catra said something just like that to me last night. All this time we've spent saving Etheria and we still just never feel like a part of it…"

Entrapta looked at her blankly.

"It all seems so ridiculous. Like we're all looking for belonging and love and the second we get it we don't know what to do with it. I've made things so difficult for Catra… Everything should be perfect now, and maybe it is. It just suddenly feels so much more complicated."

Entrapta's expression didn't change, but she put her hair around Adora's shoulders and pulled her into a hug. Adora squeezed her in return.

"Look, I'm the dumbest person I know," Adora continued. "Don't be like me. You belong with Hordak and he belongs with you. But you have to be a part of the outside world, just like me and Catra have to be. She and I have had our own ways of avoiding it, and I guess in a way we've been avoiding really being with each other. I guess there's nothing to be gained from avoiding how much more complicated real relationships are compared to just, you know, wanting someone… Bow, back me up here."

"Hordak's not going anywhere," added Bow. "Six thousand volts? You two are made for each other. I know change can be pretty scary… like when someone you've been close to for years is suddenly moving along way faster than you were prepared for… but it doesn't mean change has to be bad. It's something you'll figure out together."

Entrapta was uncharacteristically silent for a couple of moments. She looked from Adora to Bow and back again.

"Okay," she said, simply. "Thank you, friends. I'll… I'll talk to him about going to Bright Moon."

"That's the spirit," said Adora. She and Bow brought Entrapta into a tight hug.

Though Adora smiled she couldn't help but think about what Hordak had said to her. "To be one when you have been two." Adora might belong with Catra, she thought to herself, but She-Ra belonged to Etheria. Perhaps Catra was right. Perhaps it was time for her to let She-Ra go at last. But first there was something she had to know.

She was knocked out of her thoughts by a sudden outburst from Entrapta. "Ahh, I have so much new equipment I'm going to need before we go to Bright Moon! I hope there's still enough time to build everything. It's going to be *weeeird!"*

It was already getting dark by the time they'd finished their business. Entrapta had Wrong Hordak prepare a small room for them in the tower. It was a tiny, barren room adorned with a pair of unusually elegant beds which they suspected hadn't been slept in for a few decades. Still, they were clean and comfortable, and soon Bow was sound asleep, snoring peacefully.

Adora stared up at the ceiling, thoughts racing through her mind. After an hour, she sat up, dressed quietly, and snuck out of the room.

The castle was an impossible maze, but something told her she wouldn't get lost—at least, not for long. She stepped down the tower, through a corridor, room to room, without much care to her direction. She knew she was being led, until, sure enough, she found herself in a small courtyard.

"I expected you sooner," said Hordak. He was tending to a small flowerbed. To Adora's surprise the flowers looked just as sickly as those in Entrapta's lab. "The midnight cymbidium… a challenging flower whose bloom is all the lovelier when tended by night. They do not call it the one a.m. cymbidium."

Adora watched him from a distance. “You mustn’t get a lot of sleep.”

“I do not sleep,” Hordak spat. “You’re here because there’s something you wish to ask me. I allowed you to find this garden so that I might answer. I remember the mind of Horde Prime and through it I remember the mind of Catra. Hers was small and vicious and scared… much like my own. I know her, and I know you as well as she ever knew you. And she must know you so very well, or we would not be enjoying such pleasantries now, would we?”

Adora hesitated for a moment. “Do you love Entrapta?”

“Yes,” replied Hordak, without hesitation. “But that’s not the question you wish to ask.”

“But I had to be sure,” said Adora. “We’re not like the others, are we? We don’t really exist in the world like normal people, even if we both want to. I’ve tried so hard to be everything the world needs me to be because it was the right thing to do, but through it all the only thing I ever wanted was to just be Catra’s Adora. But I’m not *just* Adora, and I can’t both belong to her and not at the same time. I need to know if She-Ra can ever belong to her too.”

Hordak smiled and stood up from his flowerbed. “Oh, is that all…?” he murmured. “And what do you think I know of belonging?”

He turned to face her, his red eyes piercing the darkness. Adora took a step back.

“Look at me, Adora,” he said. “I grow flowers and concoct tea blends. Recently I’ve taken to art. Does it not appear incongruous? I thought I had a grand place in the universe once—a place of glory and power—and it meant nothing. You too, *She-Ra,* once had a destiny. Remind me, did it bring you satisfaction?”

Adora didn’t reply, but her expression betrayed her answer.

“I will never again understand the purpose of my existence, but for one point…” continued Hordak as stepped towards her. “The answer to your question is simple: to Catra there has only ever been Adora. You’re the only one who believes you need to achieve greatness as She-Ra. This wretched obsession for giving meaning to our lives is a weakness that I am pleased to have rid myself of. Catra too believed a place existed for her which would give her brief life meaning—somewhere that made her worthy of your love. Such hubris! There is no such place, there is no such worth. But there is love.”

He took another step forward and placed something into Adora’s palm. She looked down to find a single flower. It was ugly and misshapen, with wilting leaves and a brown edge to each lurid petal.

“It’s beautiful,” said Hordak, “if you look at it correctly.”

Adora looked down at it again. “Yeah,” she said. “I guess it is.”

Chapter End Notes

Entrapta chapta! Does it all make sense? Maybe. You'll all have to forgive any strange meandering as I was working some personal issues out here. Once again big thanks to anyone who's read this far.

Bliss

Chapter Summary

> While staying behind in Bright Moon, Catra has a midnight snack and a conversation with Spinnerella and Netossa in which Catra considers what happiness means for her.

Catra had never slept in Adora's old room without her. It felt almost invasive, like reading her diary—something Catra always wanted to do if Adora could ever stick to writing one. She had, at least, put an end to that stupid waterfall.

She didn't even touch the bed, instead curling up in a chair by the window, looking out into the night, eastward, to Dryl. She sat there as the sun went down, wrapped in Adora's blanket. Every so often she'd close her eyes and when she opened them again she was sure she must have had some sleep, but felt unrested. Eventually she stretched and slunk off the seat and, with a sigh, wandered off to explore the castle.

As nice and private as the cottage was, the castle was huge and interesting and, to Catra, still mostly unexplored. She couldn't remember the last time she'd prowled at night and the quiet elation that came with it. She silently crept from room to room until she finally worked up an appetite, and she snuck down to the kitchen.

She still wasn't used to the richer food of Bright Moon. After opening and sniffing almost every bowl, jar, pot and container she finally found something that smelled a little like fish. She took six more than she thought she'd actually eat, and made her way out.

"Having a midnight snack, huh?" said a voice.

Catra nearly dropped her snacks. She spun around and, in the dim light at the far end of the breakfast table was Spinnerella and Netossa. Catra glared at them.

“What are you two doing here?” she said.

Spinnerella gestured to the two ice cream tubs they had laid out in front of them.

“Midnight snack,” she said. “Would you care to join us?”

Catra hesitantly sat opposite them. Netossa turned up the light a small amount.

“I thought you two were pretending you didn’t know each other,” said Catra as she carefully laid out her fish dishes in front of her. “What happened to Mrs Dangerous and Mrs Heartbreaker?”

“We… kinda gave that up,” said Netossa guiltily. “We really thought it would be fun to relive the good old days for a while… and it was, for a while. It’s funny but even after being together for so long, you remember how good it felt to just long for someone.”

“But the thing about longing is that it only becomes good once it’s already ended,” said Spinnerella. “And besides, ice cream’s a lot more fun with two. Anyway, how have you been? I heard you and Adora have your own place now?”

“Yeah,” Catra sighed. “It’s our own little slice of paradise alright.”

Netossa and Spinnerella exchanged a meaningful glance.

“Oh, you’re into *that* part of the relationship,” said Spinnerella.

Catra looked up from her meal. “So, what, does all of Etheria have an opinion about this now? We’re doing fine!”

“Of course you are,” said Netossa. “These things just blow over. When we started dating it was like Spinny had a one-woman vendetta against the whole world, and there was definitely some friendly fire. You probably don’t remember what it was like in those days, but there was no Rebellion back then, so we’d spend weeks out there on the frontier. Now, this one time we were in this village in Plumeria, when I—”

"Is this a long story?" said Catra? "I can always get a bigger snack."

"The *point,"* Netossa continued, "is that it was hard on both of us at the start. Sometimes it can be hard to settle down, especially when things have been tough. We worked through it. And whatever it is, I'm sure you two will too."

Catra shovelled a forkful of fish into her mouth and leaned back. "Did either of you transform into an eight foot tall warrior who saved the world?"

"Well—" began Netossa.

"Because if not I don't really see how this applies. And *now* it turns out that She-Ra and Adora aren't exactly as separate as I thought, so… I don't know. It's hard for me to follow where She-Ra goes. I thought she could turn it off, but it turns out she can't. She-Ra's always going to be a part of Adora that's never mine."

To Catra's surprise, Spinnerella began to laugh.

"What's so funny?"

Spinnerella shook her head slowly. "It's just that you have two beautiful girls for the price of one, and you're acting like it's a problem! I'm just a little surprised, that's all."

"She-Ra *isn't* mine!" growled Catra.

"Netty, were we ever this young?"

"Speak for yourself. I was never this dramatic."

Catra jabbed her fork into the table. "What's *wrong* with you two? You don't get what we're going through! Adora said it herself: she's She-Ra because she can't deal with… *this.* She's She-Ra because she can't just be my Adora. Every time she becomes—or is—She-Ra she's putting a wall between everything, and between

her and me. So actually I sort of have zero beautiful girls for the price of one."

She crossed her arms and sat back morosely, her tail curled around her knees.

"So what's your plan?" said Netossa. "Are you just going to sit here and mope until she stops being She-Ra?"

Catra glowered at her petulantly. "No!"

"Did you really think having a relationship *with She-Ra* was going to be easy?"

Catra's features froze. "No!"

"'No! No!' Ugh, it would be funny if you didn't remind me so much of myself."

"Darling, maybe it's time to just take a step back," said Spinnerella, putting her arm around her. Netossa looked up at her and smiled, waved in capitulation and went back to her ice cream. "I think what Netossa is trying to say," she continued, "is that you think this is something no-one else ever has to deal with, but deep down it's really not. Your problem isn't magic; it's that you haven't figured out how to be a couple yet. I know Adora is a bit different—very different, I suppose—but you still have to work out how to be a couple. Sooner or later everyone gets to the point where *wanting* to be together just isn't enough and you have to actually figure out *how* to *live* together."

Catra shrugged and took another bite of her meal. "We did live together though, for years. We shared a bunk and everything. We at the same ration bars, ran the same drills, served the same punishments…"

"But you weren't living, were you?" said Spinnerella. "Any more than we were really living on the frontier."

Catra looked glumly at her food. She pushed it around a little with her fork.

"You know it's funny, all that time we were in the Horde, ever since I was old enough to feel like I wanted… Well, anyway, all that time I just wanted what you two have. Midnight ice cream parties or whatever. I hated all the… the *yearning.* It hurt so much I felt like I was going to die."

"But secretly, you kinda liked it though, didn't you?" said Netossa.

Catra shrugged. "Yeah…"

"Deep down, feeling like you were going to die was the most alive you ever felt, right?"

Catra laughed sardonically. "Yeah."

"Like I said, longing is great, once it's over," said Spinnerella. "And in a way, it's the easy bit. It burns so hot, but then one day the yearning's over and you finally think 'this is it'—except it's never 'it', and then however good things get, you start missing the yearning."

She looked wistfully at her wife, who took her hand and gave it a small squeeze.

Catra looked from one of them to the other and couldn't help but imagine herself and Adora in their place—sitting some day in the future, remembering how different life used to be when she was, well, the way she was. And wasn't that the dream? One day all the anger and fear would be left far behind. Life could be so different: dinners for two, a day by the lake, quiet domestic bliss… A change from all the chaos.

But of course all of that had been on the table before, and every time she picked more chaos.

"Why do we do it?" asked Catra. "I mean you *know* it was bad when you were pining for each other, right? Or you wouldn't have

given up pretending to be apart so quickly. And I hated being apart from Adora… Why can't we just be happy when things finally work out?"

Netossa shrugged. "If we were rational we'd never be in love. Maybe that's what love is, or maybe we just don't know what we want. I guess we're never really satisfied, but that doesn't mean you can't be happy, so long as you let yourself."

"I'm not used to being happy," said Catra with a sigh. "Back in the Horde growing up happy was never an option. They trained us to fight and die, not to grow old with anyone. It's so much harder than I ever thought it would be. Wanting Adora felt so simple. Like I just felt so driven every day, no matter how bad it got. And now there's so much time and it feels so empty. I can't blame Adora for wanting to escape it all as She-Ra."

Netossa gave Catra a sympathetic look.

"I know it hurts, but it doesn't have to," she said. "Maybe neither of us know what it's like to deal with She-Ra problems, but I know what it looks like when you build a wall to protect yourself, and you and Adora have always had some problems with that. Both of you are pretty used to not getting what you want. You're so used to it that even though you've got the girl of your dreams you've just found a whole new way to sit and wait for her to come home."

Catra said nothing. Her ears lay flat.

"Catra, you found it in you to let yourself be loved, and that's amazing," said Spinnerella, "but it's not the same as letting yourself be in love. At some point you have to accept getting what you want. You really can have it all. And if Adora can't be just Adora then you can have whatever else she is too."

"It's going to feel complicated," added Netossa. "Trust me, it's always more complicated than you think it'll be, all the time. Everyone's going to tell you that love is passion or heartbreak or

blah blah blah—but let me tell you what love really is: love is when you wake up every day—*every* day—and you power through all the big things and all the little things that make you feel a like you're completely losing your mind. You put a pin in that idea you have passionate, tender romance and you deal with ten stupid, annoying, embarrassing things every day. You keep going until you have opinions on drapes. That's what love is."

Catra poked sullenly at her food for a while, deep in thought.

"I guess I haven't made this whole thing easy for Adora" she said at last. "I guess I haven't really made it easy for myself either."

"We've all been there," said Netossa.

"All I've ever wanted was Adora. Having her is so much better, and I want to wake up every morning and just be normal and quiet and boring. But I don't think I'm ready to let go of wanting her just yet. Is it really so bad to want it to keep hurting just a little?"

"Not at all," said Spinnerella. She looked at her wife as she spoke. "But you can be happy while it hurts too. Netossa and I thought we'd have to choose between them and pretend we weren't as… comfortable as we're used to, but maybe it doesn't have to be that way."

Catra smiled weakly. She lay down her fork and stood up. "Maybe I should leave you to some of that domestic bliss. I guess I have some thinking to do anyway."

"So what are you going to do?" said Spinnerella.

Catra stood up. "I guess I'm going to stop building a wall and go and find my girlfriend."

Netossa grinned and shrugged. "I mean alright. It's the middle of the night though. Aren't you even going to finish your snack first?"

“What do you mean?” asked Catra. “I’ve eaten the whole thing.”

The others looked at the tiny circle of visible ceramic surrounded by mounds of untouched seafood laid out in front of her.

“Uhuh,” said Netossa.

Catra dabbed the corners of her mouth. She turned to go, but stopped herself for a moment.

“Thank you,” she said. “For, you know, the advice or whatever.”

She hurried out of the room.

For some time afterwards the room was again quiet, with only the sounds of spoons scraping the sides of the ice cream tubs. After a while Netossa broke the silence.

“Overall, I’d say I give the best advice,” she said.

“Oh, stop it, Netty,” said Spinnerella in mock annoyance.

They kissed, and went to look for another two tubs of ice cream.

Adora rushed through the night towards Bright Moon. Her mind felt electric with determination. She finally knew exactly what she had to do.

She focused intensely, and by the time Crypto Castle had vanished behind the mountain pass, Swift Wind appeared from the opposite horizon.

“Okay, so I know I said I was always magically attuned to you and ready to fly to your aid at a moment’s notice,” he said, “but I didn’t realise this would include the middle of the night. What’s the emergency?”

Adora mounted him. “I need to see Catra right now. Take me back to Bright Moon.”

“Sure, Bright Moon. I can get behind that. That’s where bed is…”

They soared until Dryl was long behind them, and the vast flatland of Bright Moon opened up before them. Adora rested her head on Swift Wind’s neck, exhausted, until they were finally over the Whispering Woods.

“Wait, did you hear that?” she said, sitting up.

She listened intently. Through the noise of crickets, the scurry of nocturnal critters and the wind, on the very edge of hearing, broke the distant sound of swearing.

“Catra?” she called out. “Catra!”

Catra had just finished extracting herself from a tangle of brambles when Adora and Swift Wind landed. Adora was already dismounting before they’d even touched the ground. Catra looked up in astonishment.

“Adora!” she cried.

The two of them rushed towards each other and embraced with a deep and loving kiss.

“Adora, I’m so sorry,” said Catra. “I’ve been so difficult all this time, and… and…”

“No, I’ve been the worst,” said Adora. “I was so caught up trying to be something bigger and more important, I guess I forgot what really matters. I haven’t been thinking clearly in so long. I’m sorry I wasn’t there when you needed me, but I’m back now.”

“You did what you had to do, for Etheria. You were always there for me, whether you’ve got that stupid tiara on or not; I was just too stupid to see it. But I finally get it now. I want to finally let myself be happy, Adora.”

They touched their foreheads and closed their eyes. A second passed before Catra sensed an intrusive stare. She opened one eye and looked at Swift Wind.

"Wow, this is just such a beautiful moment," he said. "You guys are just so perfect together."

"Oh good," said Catra dryly. "You brought the horse."

Adora gave her a nervous grin. They stepped apart.

"Catra, what are you *doing* out here?" said Adora.

Catra rubbed the back of her neck "Well… I was heading to Dryl… to be with you. It seemed… Well, it felt kind of romantic and dramatic, I guess. At least it did before I ran into miles and miles of tangled roots and thorns and all these stupid little burrows everywhere. Stop looking at me like that."

If Adora's eyes opened any wider they would've taken over her face. She took Catra's hand and led her to Swift Wind.

"Come on," she said. "You were right yesterday: there's still one last place out there where it was just you and me. Maybe it's not forever anymore, but I think it's time we get back to basics, just for a bit. The world can wait for a day."

"You really mean it?"

Adora helped Catra onto Swift Wind. "Let's go to the Fright Zone, or whatever's left of it. It's time we just got it all out of our systems. I just need to stop by the cottage quickly first."

Morning broke in Dryl. Bow was awoken by the loud industrious clangs of hammering and machining. He stretched and stared

wearily at the ceiling.

"Morning, Adora," he said, then turned to face the empty bed next to him. He climbed out of bed, got dressed, and followed the source of the racket. After a half dozen dead ends and tripwires he finally found his way to the castle's great hall, where Entrapta was already hard at work, assisted by the Hordaks and Emily. The hall was strewn with wires and huge lengths of metal, huge brass gears and motors. The air was thick with the smell of welding fumes and engine grease. And there in the centre was a giant silver box. He stared at it for a moment, followed the cables running to it from the walls, and realised to his amazement that it was Entrapta's lab, extracted whole from its elevator shaft. They were fitting it with *legs.*

"Wrong Hordak—run that wiring through to the power cells!" yelled Entrapta, herself performing three tasks at once. "Emily—no, we need a 12-inch sprocket for the rear gearbox, not the 10-inch! Hordak—go and pick yourself out a nice outfit for the party. I want to make a good impression when we get to Bright Moon!"

Bow couldn't help but laugh at the absurdity of it all. Still, he had to hand it to Adora—their mission was definitely a success.

Entrapta noticed him and climbed down from the top of the lab. "Hey, Bow! Hordak said Adora left this for you."

She passed him a neatly folded piece of paper. He opened it up and read it twice.

Bow,

Gone to be with Catra. Don't wait up. Make sure Entrapta makes it to party. I owe you one.

Adora.

He sighed. Glimmer wasn't going to like this.

"Of course I don't like it!" said Glimmer, holding up the pad so everyone around the conference table could see. "How could you just let her go, Bow?"

Bow spoke loudly over the noise of Entrapta's ongoing construction. "It was the middle of the night! Besides, shouldn't she be back in Bright Moon by now?"

"No, she never showed up. And now Catra's gone looking for Adora. I guess she isn't there in Dryl with you now?"

"No, no sign of her here."

"I'm sure there're both fine," said Netossa. "They can handle themselves just fine."

"There's really nothing to be upset about," added Spinnerella.

Glimmer breathed deeply. "I'm not upset. I'm just freaking out a little bit. The party is tonight, and we were kind of counting on She-Ra being there… And besides, I just really wanted everyone I care about to be there. It just feels like it's falling apart now. Bow, I really wish you were here."

"Entrapta says we'll be in Bright Moon in a few hours," said Bow. "Oh, and she's, you know, bringing the whole family. So that'll be… nice. Don't worry, everything's going to be okay."

Glimmer smiled weakly. "Okay. I—" She hesitated for a moment, aware of Netossa and Spinnerella in the room with her. "I love you, Bow."

"I love you too, Glimmer."

She turned off the pad. Netossa and Spinnerella exchanged a meaningful glance.

“I’m sure Catra and Adora will be back in no time,” said Netossa.

Glimmer looked out the window towards the distant mountains. Despite everything a sudden sense of peace washed over her. She broke into a resigned laugh.

“No, I don’t think they will, and that’s okay. We’ll do just fine by ourselves. Wherever they’ve gone, they’re finally, finally getting a little alone time. They’ve needed this for a really, really long time.”

Love

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra return to the Fright Zone to get closure. Meanwhile, at the party in Bright Moon, their friends each come to term with their experiences.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Whatever the Fright Zone had once been, it was now unrecognisable. The outer reaches were now so overgrown that it was as though there'd never been a city there at all. Moss and vines covered every vertical surface. The faint putrid odour that once plagued it was replaced with the scent of wildflowers. More than anything else it was now silent. It was as though it had been left abandoned for a century or more, although it had actually been only a few months. The whole place felt eerily out of time and space.

Adora had Swift Wind leave them at the edge of the inner complex. From there they continued on foot over the uneven, changed landscape.

"How does it feel to be back?" asked Adora.

"Weird," said Catra. "I know this place is full of terrible memories, but it kinda feels like home. This was the last place my world made sense. Life sucked here, but I was pretty good at it. And now… Now it's dead."

Adora took her hand. "It doesn't look so dead to me," she said. "I've never seen it so alive. Come on, let's keep moving."

They wandered through across the cracked and broken landscape, helping each other over the upturned masonry and tangled roots. They pressed on until the buildings became taller and denser.

Soon the foliage became a little sparser and the twisted spires of metal and concrete lent the area a sense of familiarity. The lanes became easier to navigate.

"Actually I think I prefer to think of it as dead," said Catra, eventually, as she helped Adora up onto a rusting walkway. "The Fright Zone, I mean. A couple of days ago I just wanted to see somewhere where I felt like I was in control, or you know, whatever—but now I just wish I could see this whole place turned to ash. It would be so… freeing."

"Are you sorry we came here?" said Adora. She stopped for a moment to get her bearings.

"What? Of course not. It's just, well…" Catra sighed. Every instinct told her to keep her feelings to herself, but she pressed on regardless. "I really wanted to be different. I hate that I was so good at being a Force Captain; so good at living under the Horde; so good at being miserable. When we finally found each other again it felt like… well, it felt like salvation." She paused and looked up at Adora. "It's this way, dummy. Let's keep walking."

Adora trailed behind her but said nothing. After a while Catra slowed down, and began to speak again.

"I *liked* the person I became when we got together. For the first time in my life I felt, I don't know, peaceful? You know all my life I had this idea that love was meant to hurt. Being in love with you hurt so much for years, Adora."

"I never meant to hurt you."

"You never hurt me; I just spent a long time looking for pain. Then suddenly everything just stopped hurting and it was *incredible.* It felt sweet and soft… Well, you know." Catra blushed. "For a while I could just let that feeling wash over me and I loved that, but I just can't keep it up. I wish I could capture that feeling in a little trap and hold onto it forever, but it turns out life's just too complicated to feel that way all the time. But feeling that way

made me a better person, and who am I now? A good Force Captain again? I don't want that any more. I never want that person back again. Somehow it just feels like if only I could see this place truly gone I'd be free. But here it still is, even if it's in ruins."

Adora grasped her hand and gave it a tender squeeze. Catra smiled forlornly.

"You know, I kind of envy you," said Adora. "The other day when you said it was easy for me because I was a Princess, you were wrong, but not for the reason you'd think. I never told you this, but after I left the Horde I really didn't know what—didn't know *how* to feel for a really long time. I guess I wanted to be happy. Bow and Glimmer definitely wanted me to be happy, and sure, we had some amazing times. But well, those times couldn't last forever…"

Catra gave her an embarrassed grin. "Yeah, sorry about some of that…"

"That's not what I meant. I was never content. Do you know how on edge I was every time I was happy? In the Horde I was only ever happy with you, and that was never very far from a punishment, or a fight, or some other awful thing. When I left it was a bit better, but not a lot. Happiness has never brought me peace. Except as She-Ra… She-Ra can handle anything, better than I ever could. She doesn't have to be on edge."

"I had no idea you felt that way," said Catra. "Do you, you know, still feel that way?"

"Sometimes, I guess," sighed Adora. "I'm glad you got to experience real peace, even if just for a little while Catra. You know what that means for you, but for me, it's She-Ra. She's become a crutch, I guess, but today I don't feel like I need her. Maybe I'm ready to try and find out how to feel real contentment all by myself."

They turned a corner into a familiar complex of buildings. They were getting close.

“Maybe I’ve made you lean on She-Ra too much lately,” said Catra, “I can’t feel contentment all the time. Neither can you, or anyone, probably. We’re going to have to learn how to live together, and how to be happy even when things aren’t perfect. For a long time for me love was pain, and now it doesn’t hurt anymore. When it stopped feeling perfect I guess I just wanted to bring the pain back again. I’m sorry I made it so hard for you.”

“I’m sorry I checked out when you needed me most,” said Adora.

They stopped and embraced. It seemed to them both that a tension had been lifted, and almost involuntarily they laughed together.

“Do you ever think we maybe don’t have the healthiest relationship?” said Catra.

“I guess,” said Adora, “but look around you. Look at what we came from… what they did to us. I think we’re doing pretty well, even if we don’t get the classic happy ending.”

“Maybe no-one gets a happy ending,” said Catra. “I mean look at all our friends. How many of us are really that perfect? But I think love might be worth it. We just have to keep waking up, every day, and— Is that what I think it is?”

Adora spun round and followed to where Catra was pointing. They were stood in front of a tall and twisted pile of metal at the base of the central spire. Smiles slowly crept over their faces as realisation hit them.

“The barracks!” they said together.

They took turns clearing a pile of debris from the doorway and headed inside.

This was where it had all begun. For years, this had been home. Like all things in the Fright Zone it was a mess. The roof had partially collapsed and the entrance hall was overrun with grass and vines. As they made their way up the damaged staircase they noticed that most of the cells were in disarray from the former-Horde's hasty evacuation. But there on level three everything seemed just the way they remembered it.

They looked at the narrow metal bunk.

"I can't believe we used to sleep here," said Adora.

Catra threw herself down into the bottom bunk onto the damp, rotting mattress. It was cramped and dismal and she could feel every scratch and rivet in the metal floor through the paper-thin padding. It was heaven.

A moment later she spotted a lockbox by the side of the bed. She sat up and opened it.

"No way!" she said. "Adora, my first knife is still here! The one Shadow Weaver let me have when I was five because she said it would shut me up. Heh, I guess I showed her… And it's still sharp!"

Adora giggled to herself. She sat and opened her bag and tossed Catra a wrapped sandwich. Catra looked at it curiously.

"So that's what you went back to the cottage for? Egg salad?"

"Catra, there's nothing to eat out here. I had no idea how long we'd be gone," said Adora. "But that's not all. I also brought…"

She trilled an imitation drum roll and with a "ta-da!" pulled her long-unplayed zither out of her bag. Catra laughed uproariously.

"You didn't!" she said.

Adora couldn't play the instrument and she couldn't sing, but it didn't matter. She played for a while and Catra clapped and

cheered. They ate the sandwiches and sat and talked for hours. They explored all the once-forbidden areas of the barracks and scratched their initials into the walls and doors. When the sun began to go down they climbed up to the tallest peak of Hordak's spire and watched the moons rise together.

Adora cradled Catra in her arms as they lay on the smooth metal surface together. Catra rested her head on Adora's chest and purred softly.

"Thank you," said Catra, at last. "You know, for coming here with me. I know it must have been weird for you coming back. I know it was never exactly great here."

"I'm glad we came," said Adora. "Maybe we both needed it. It's nice to put everything into perspective and just start again."

As sunset gave way to twilight, the stars began to come out, one by one.

"We're going to have to say goodbye to this place, aren't we?" she asked. "To the way we used to be…"

"Yeah," said Adora, "but let's stay just a little longer first."

Catra breathed a meditative sigh, but gave into the warmth of the embrace. She looked up at Adora and a slow, devious grin crept over her face. She shifted upwards until they were looking into each other's eyes. Adora pushed Catra's growing hair behind her ears.

"It's starting to get pretty late," said Catra. "We're missing Glimmer's party. What happened to She-Ra securing the lasting peace of Etheria?"

"Glimmer's got this. She always has," said Adora. "Bright Moon needs the image of She-Ra, not the person. Honestly, it was always just an excuse. She-Ra's just always around, right on the edge of everything, but I wanted to keep her to myself—keep being the hero—and that meant keeping the two of me separate.

It meant keeping her from you. But I don't want to do that anymore."

They gazed at each other. They felt the rhythm of their breath, of their heartbeats; Catra's weight and warmth on Adora's chest; Adora's hands on Catra's cheek, on her lips…

"You're so beautiful," whispered Catra. "Maybe the world can wait for a while longer."

Adora looked up at Catra, her face haloed in the moonlight.

"Catra, I want to give you something," she said.

Catra laughed softly. "Well, I want to give you something too…"

"I mean I want to give you something… well, something special," continued Adora. Her heart was racing. "There's that part of me I always kept for the world; that was never your Adora. I don't want to keep living that way. I want to give She-Ra to you. I want all of me to belong to you."

Catra looked down breathlessly. Her heart felt like a knot. "Do you mean it?" she whispered.

Adora pulled Catra closer and kissed her deeply and lovingly. The moment lasted an eternity until at last the kiss broke. Adora extended a hand and summoned the sword. She pressed her lips to Catra's cheek.

"For the honour of Greyskull," she whispered.

Twilight had long given way to night before the two of them finally set back off to Bright Moon. They took one last look back at the barracks and turned away, knowing they would never return. They

broke into one of the depots and found a skiff with an engine that wasn't overrun by weeds and just enough fuel for at least part of the journey, and made their way by moonlight, back...

"…Home," murmured Catra. "I can't believe I miss it this much. The lake, Bright Moon… all our friends. Somehow it feels like we were away longer."

Adora steered the skiff across the plain, her hair loose and blowing in the wind behind her. Catra gazed up at her.

"Adora, are we… fixed?"

Adora had to think about it for a moment. "I don't know," she said. "Are we?"

They were both silent for a while.

"It doesn't feel like it would be that easy," said Catra. "Nothing ever is. I can't promise being together is always going to be easy, for either of us. But so what? Being fixed is overrated. I don't want to be perfect. I like the way we are already."

Adora smiled at her. "Hey, so long as I love you and you love me, we got this."

Catra smiled back at her.

"You know, I've been thinking a lot lately, about all our friends," Adora went on, "and all their advice… all their hopes, fears, wants… I don't think any of us ever really get fixed—we just get a little better every time. And there's something else too: there's a lot of love out there. None of us have it all figured out, but maybe that's fine. I think maybe when there's so much love in the world, things can only get better…

> *…And perhaps we all have a different idea of what love means," she continued. "Sometimes it's when all your desire turns to comfort and security..."*

Netossa cast her eyes across the crowded ballroom. In Adora's absence she'd stepped up to serve the crown of Bright Moon as she had many times before, but with the evening's plans now finalised it was, at last, time to enjoy herself. She stretched as best she could in her tight gown and found herself instinctively thinking to the end of the night: a bubble bath, an indulgent bedtime snack, a soft bed…

She passed through the crowd to look for her wife. It took her a few minutes to find her, but there, at last, was Spinnerella.

The feeling hit her suddenly and surprisingly. Perhaps it was that poor Catra girl's influence at work, and a day thinking about young love had got to her more than she'd expected, but Netossa was suddenly lost for words. The sight of Spinnerella, as elegant as ever, hit her suddenly and absolutely, and suddenly they were at the frontier again, two strangers drawn to each other, and all the world an irrelevance. She pushed forward through the crowd as though in a trance, enraptured.

Spinnerella looked up as she approached and they locked eyes. She could feel intensity burning from her. She froze in place, suddenly disarmed and willingly helpless. As soon as Netossa stood in front of her she found herself instinctively extending her hand. Netossa took it tenderly and softly kissed the back of it.

It seemed strange that for all their efforts to rekindle that feeling it should happen here and now, neither of them knowing what to say, shy as girls. Spinnerella found herself overwhelmed by a desire to kiss her there and then. Netossa caught her eye and they felt it—the yearning—together. Wordlessly they agreed to let it burn, just this once.

"Why yes," said Spinnerella, without having to be asked, "I would love to dance."

> *"…or sometimes it's helping others to become more than they once were."*

Entrapta lead Hordak through the ballroom. At first, faced with the anxious reality of finally being present, he had felt inclined to stay with the lab—now a forty-foot hexapod looming ominously outside the main gates—but Entrapta had enticed him inside at last. Before he knew it they were standing before Queen Glimmer, and it was finally official.

Entrapta gave Glimmer, then Bow, a spine-crushing hug. Glimmer gave her a welcoming kiss on the cheek, and then turned to Hordak.

"Welcome to Bright Moon," she said, and stretched to give him a kiss on the cheek as well.

He turned to Entrapta with a smile, but he noticed she'd already taken a step back. Her smile had changed from beaming to acquiescent, and he suddenly realised her presence here was a gift to him. She gestured to him to keep going as she took a step back, but he reached out and grasped her hand.

He leant down and whispered in her ear: "I will always need you. This is for the both of us."

She looked up at him with a cautious expression. "Are you sure? I don't want to hold you back. It's just all so… difficult."

"That it is," said Hordak. "But it's so much easier together. We are two where we were once each one. That is progress."

She smiled at him and stepped forward again, and soon it was as though the four of them were all old friends and the past five months of isolation had never happened. Entrapta laughed and smiled and clung to Hordak's arm devotedly. As it turned out, people were a lot easier when she wasn't alone.

"By the way," said Hordak, eventually, with his usual sinister tone. "I have prepared a very amusing joke for exactly this situation…"

"Maybe love's just about allowing yourself to be damaged with someone else, when being better just seems too hard…"

Mermista and Sea Hawk danced slowly and silently, the very picture of elegance. That was wrong enough, but Sea Hawk's quiet grace was just too much to bear. Before long Mermista couldn't take it any longer, and she groaned loudly.

"Ugh, come *on,* Sea Hawk! No shanties? No annoying little bits of praise? No swooning? Nothing?"

He raised his eyebrows. "My beloved, this *is* a first! Swooning is, of course, my forte! But here and now? Well, it just wouldn't be appropriate."

"Not approp—? What's going on with you? You remember how this works, right? You drive me crazy, I push back, we laugh, we cry, we fight. It's super hot. What happened to that?"

"You haven't quite been yourself either, my jewel of the sea," he said. "Why I can hardly remember the last time you threw heavy furniture at me."

"Well *yeah,* dummy, how am I meant to get properly mad at you when you're being normal? Honestly, I can't take much more of this. It's making me feel—" She paused, mid-step, in sudden realisation, and broke into a disbelieving smile. "You're doing this on purpose, aren't you, you… you devious cur!"

Sea Hawk couldn't hold his straight face any longer. "I haven't sung a shanty in days! It's been a challenge, but it worked, right? I know how anxious you've been about this party, about Salineas, about you and me… You need me to frustrate you. It makes it all safe."

Mermista stopped still and looked at him, and for a moment her mind raced through a dozen sardonic come backs and dismissive remarks, but she couldn't hold onto any of them. Involuntarily, she broke into a genuine mirthful laugh.

"I hate it when you're right," she said. "You really are the most annoying person I've ever met."

“Does this mean I can finally sing a shanty?” he asked. “I’ve been holding one in for days…”

“So help me, Sea Hawk, if you sing a shanty I’m going to lose it!” snapped Mermista, but a look in her eye told him that she’d really love nothing more.

She took a deep breath, pulled him back into her arms, and they resumed dancing.

“Look, I’m sorry,” she said, “for putting a wall between us, and for, you know, just being weird or whatever. I’ve been wrestling with some bad memories lately and I thought I was doing the right thing by pushing you away. But you actually cherish all the messed up things about me, just like how I cherish how much you suck. I know I’ve been difficult.”

“Loving you has always been the grandest adventure,” said Sea Hawk. “What’s the fun of an adventure that’s easy?”

Mermista leaned in and kissed him. “Onward, to adventure!” she said.

> *“…or it’s just patiently building what we need to finally be authentic with each other.”*

Glimmer and Bow stood on the dais at the head of the ballroom, finally free of the last of the official greetings. Everything was going better than she’d hoped. Even the delegates from the border towns, who’d come at the promise of meeting She-Ra, seemed satisfied. Glimmer breathed in relief and surveyed the room with a touch of pride.

“It still feels weird doing this without all our friends here,” she said. “I thought I’d be mad about it, but in a strange way I’m glad Adora and Catra chose something bigger. I guess I’ve been pretty bad lately at deciding what’s really important.”

Bow reached out and took her hand. “No, that’s not true. You’ve been a wonderful friend, and an amazing Queen.”

Glimmer shrugged. “Maybe that’s part of the problem. Sometimes I just don’t want to be a Queen. That’s why I pushed Adora into representing Bright Moon so much, which wasn’t exactly fair. And how much pressure I put on you…” She looked up at him and blushed. “I mean, not that I didn’t want—”

“So did I,” said Bow. “I mean I still do. I was just scared, I guess, of what would happen to our friendship. I guess I’m not amazing at handling change. I got really good at being the friendship guy. It’s been a lot harder to move on from that than I expected.

“I get that,” said Glimmer. “I thought I could handle being a friend, a Queen and a partner all at once, but I can’t. There’s always a conflict no matter what I do. There are a lot of things I need from you, Bow, but I’ve been pretty unfair to you. I tried so hard to keep all that public decorum because the most important thing I needed from you was to still be your friend. I want you to want me like I want you, but still need you to see me the way you always have. I need you to be innocent, because our best friend thing mattered more than anything.”

She became suddenly aware that they’d moved much closer. She placed her hand on Bow’s chest, and in return he placed his on her waist.

“However else I see you,” he said, “whatever else happens in our lives, and however you want me, in the middle of it all I will always love you the way I always have. I could never let go of that.”

Glimmer smiled with a tear in her eye, and moved her hand up to Bow’s cheek. “Even when I need you to look at me the way you did the other night?”

Bow pulled her closer, until their lips were almost touching. “Even then.”

Glimmer paused for a moment, suddenly aware of herself, of the crowd, of the eminence of the event. She looked out over the sea

of people, and then back to Bow.

"To heck with decorum," she said, and kissed him passionately.

"And what's love to you, Adora?" asked Catra.

"I don't know," said Adora. "But we have a lifetime to figure it out together."

The next night the heat finally broke. A gentle rain swept over the Kingdom of Bright Moon. In the following days the earth around the cottage smelled rich and alive. The rain gave way to cool summer nights, and days later Catra and Adora were once again lying together on the roof, staring at the stars.

"We should invite everyone for a day by the lake," said Catra. "I still feel bad that we missed seeing all our friends together."

"I think that would be really nice," said Adora. "I'm sure everyone would be happy for a little break. No pressure, no dress-up. I'm sure it would be a nice change after all the stress."

Adora closed her eyes a little, half-drifting into sleep. It lasted through a few minutes of silence until Catra spoke up again: "Adora?"

"Yes, Catra?" said Adora. She opened her eyes.

"I don't think that's all I missed. Do you remember when I told you I really did want to go to that dumb party with you? Well it wasn't just because I wanted to spend time with you. It's just something stupid that's been stuck in my mind since we got back, but I was looking forward, well… I wanted a dance with you. A real one, for once, as a couple."

Adora beamed and sat up. “Really? I never expected that.”

“Yeah, well, sometimes I surprise even myself.”

Adora stood up and extended her hand.

“What? Now?” said Catra. “There’s not even any music.”

“Why not?” said Adora. “It’s not like there’s anyone watching.”

Catra took Adora’s hand. They climbed down to the ground and, with a couple of false leads as they worked out the placement of hands, began to move to a slow rhythm. And there in the moonlight, in the peaceful clearing by the cottage, gazing into each other’s eyes, they danced.

Chapter End Notes

This is it, the end at last. This story has been a joy to write and I'm so glad to share it. Once again, thank you to anyone who's read through and I hope you've enjoyed it. Comments are very welcome.

This was a challenging story to write and edit, and it's been quite a personal experience. It might've turned out a bit messy and confused in places, but I'm still very happy with it. I'm planning at least two further She-Ra fanfics. I hope some of you will enjoy those when I finally write them too.

Much love to all.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!